Politics Subject Board
2024
Examiners' Report

Version History

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Politics FHS 2024 – exam performance statistics by paper and school

No statistics are given for papers taken by 2 candidates or fewer. Only the mean and standard deviation are given for papers taken by 5 candidates or fewer.

Take up, mean, standard deviation, maximum and minimum mark

Paper name then paper code then school	Take up	Mean	St Dev	Max	Min
Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice	**37**	**66.9**	**5.3**		
A15601W1	**37**	**66.9**	**5.3**		
DMHP	3	65.3	1.5		
DPPE	34	67.0	5.5	82	56
British Politics and Government since 1900	**79**	**64.1**	**8.2**	**81**	**35**
A12720W1	**79**	**64.1**	**8.2**	**81**	**35**
DMHP	18	66.9	4.4	73	59
DPPE	61	63.3	8.9	81	35
Comparative Demographic Systems	**1**				
A12741W1	**1**				
DPPE	1				
Comparative Government	**58**	**66.2**	**6.9**	**85**	**43**
A12719W1	**58**	**66.2**	**6.9**	**85**	**43**
DMHP	7	66.9	6.3	76	57
DPPE	51	66.1	7.0	85	43
Comparative Political Economy	**30**				
A17325W1	**30**				
DMHP	2				
DPPE	28	67.4	5.5	77	54
Government and Politics of the United States	**25**	**66.2**	**4.3**		
A12722W1	**25**	**66.2**	**4.3**		
DMHP	3	68.7	4.2		

DPPE	22	65.8	4.3	73	57
International Relations	**157**				
A12731W1	**156**	**64.8**	**7.9**	**83**	**27**
DMHP	25	64.1	5.0	73	54
DPPE	131	65.0	8.3	83	27
A18773W1	**1**				
DPPE	1				
International Relations in the Era of the Cold War	**26**	**66.8**	**5.4**	**76**	**54**
A12730W1	**26**	**66.8**	**5.4**	**76**	**54**
DMHP	6	67.3	3.4	72	64
DPPE	20	66.6	6.0	76	54
International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars	**9**				
A12729W1	**9**				
DMHP	1				
DPPE	8	68.4	3.5	75	64
Marx and Marxism	**14**				
A12734W1	**14**				
DMHP	2				
DPPE	12	68.6	4.4	74	61
Modern British Government and Politics	**19**	**64.5**	**4.6**		
A12721W1	**19**	**64.5**	**4.6**		
DMHP	4	66.8	3.9		
DPPE	15	63.9	4.7	72	54
Political Sociology	**100**				
A12737W1	**99**	**65.4**	**5.8**	**78**	**48**
DMHP	13	63.9	5.9	70	48
DPPE	86	65.7	5.7	78	49
A18776W1	**1**				
DPPE	1				

Political Thought: Bentham to Weber	**16**				
A12733W1	**16**				
DMHP	2				
DPPE	14	68.6	2.8	74	62
Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau	**13**	**67.2**	**4.2**		
A12732W1	**13**	**67.2**	**4.2**		
DMHP	4	66.5	1.9		
DPPE	9	67.4	5.0	77	63
Politics in China	**11**	**66.4**	**4.2**	**73**	**60**
A12743W1	**11**	**66.4**	**4.2**	**73**	**60**
DPPE	11	66.4	4.2	73	60
Politics in Europe	**7**	**63.7**	**8.2**	**79**	**55**
A12723W1	**7**	**63.7**	**8.2**	**79**	**55**
DPPE	7	63.7	8.2	79	55
Politics in Latin America	**7**	**64.0**	**8.8**	**71**	**45**
A12726W1	**7**	**64.0**	**8.8**	**71**	**45**
DPPE	7	64.0	8.8	71	45
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union	**16**	**65.9**	**5.3**		
A12724W1	**16**	**65.9**	**5.3**		
DMHP	5	65.0	7.2		
DPPE	11	66.4	4.6	75	62
Politics in South Asia	**9**	**67.1**	**4.1**		
A12727W1	**9**	**67.1**	**4.1**		
DMHP	3	66.3	4.7		
DPPE	6	67.5	4.1	74	63
Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa	**21**	**67.3**	**4.0**		
A12725W1	**21**	**67.3**	**4.0**		
DMHP	5	69.2	3.9		
DPPE	16	66.6	3.9	72	55

Politics in the Middle East	**22**	**68.0**	**4.8**	**78**	**60**
A12728W1	**22**	**68.0**	**4.8**	**78**	**60**
DMHP	7	67.1	4.7	71	60
DPPE	15	68.4	5.0	78	62
Social Policy	**34**	**66.3**	**4.8**		
A12740W1	**34**	**66.3**	**4.8**		
DMHP	5	67.8	3.3		
DPPE	29	66.0	5.1	78	55
Sociological Theory	**20**				
A12735W1	**20**				
DMHP	1				
DPPE	19	65.9	5.5	76	57
Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory	**22**				
A17606W1	**22**				
DMHP	2				
DPPE	20	67.9	4.3	80	58
Special Subject in Politics: International Security and Conflict	**46**	**66.5**	**4.8**	**73**	**48**
A15594W1	**46**	**66.5**	**4.8**	**73**	**48**
DMHP	8	67.1	2.5	71	64
DPPE	38	66.3	5.1	73	48
The Politics of the European Union	**7**				
A12744W1	**7**				
DMHP	2				
DPPE	5	58.0	16.2		
Theory of Politics	**120**				
A15005W1	**119**	**66.5**	**4.6**	**77**	**54**
DMHP	25	66.0	4.9	74	58
DPPE	94	66.6	4.6	77	54
A15005X1	**1**				

DPPE	1				
Thesis in Politics	**26**	**65.0**	**14.8**	**78**	**0**
A12746S1	**26**	**65.0**	**14.8**	**78**	**0**
DMHP	6	54.8	26.9	68	0
DPPE	20	68.1	7.5	78	54
Grand Total	**952**	**65.9**	**6.6**	**85**	**0**

Bands of marks

Paper name then code then school	Take up	% 70-100	% 60-69	% 50-59	% 40-49	% 30-39	% <30
Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice	**37**						
A15601W1	**37**						
DMHP	3						
DPPE	34	29%	62%	9%	0%	0%	0%
British Politics and Government since 1900	**79**	**28%**	**43%**	**22%**	**4%**	**1%**	**0%**
A12720W1	**79**	**28%**	**43%**	**22%**	**4%**	**1%**	**0%**
DMHP	18	39%	56%	6%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	61	25%	39%	26%	5%	2%	0%
Comparative Demographic Systems	**1**						
A12741W1	**1**						
DPPE	1						
Comparative Government	**58**	**28%**	**59%**	**10%**	**2%**	**0%**	**0%**
A12719W1	**58**	**28%**	**59%**	**10%**	**2%**	**0%**	**0%**
DMHP	7	29%	57%	14%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	51	27%	59%	10%	2%	0%	0%
Comparative Political Economy	**30**						
A17325W1	**30**						
DMHP	2						
DPPE	28	32%	61%	7%	0%	0%	0%
Government and Politics of the United States	**25**						
A12722W1	**25**						
DMHP	3						
DPPE	22	23%	68%	9%	0%	0%	0%
International Relations	**157**						
A12731W1	**156**	**27%**	**54%**	**15%**	**0%**	**1%**	**1%**
DMHP	25	20%	56%	20%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	131	28%	53%	14%	0%	1%	2%

A18773W1	**1**						
DPPE	1						
International Relations in the Era of the Cold War	**26**	**38%**	**46%**	**15%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
A12730W1	**26**	**38%**	**46%**	**15%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
DMHP	6	33%	67%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	20	40%	40%	20%	0%	0%	0%
International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars	**9**						
A12729W1	**9**						
DMHP	1						
DPPE	8	25%	75%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Marx and Marxism	**14**						
A12734W1	**14**						
DMHP	2						
DPPE	12	50%	50%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Modern British Government and Politics	**19**						
A12721W1	**19**						
DMHP	4						
DPPE	15	13%	73%	13%	0%	0%	0%
Political Sociology	**100**						
A12737W1	**99**	**19%**	**63%**	**13%**	**2%**	**0%**	**0%**
DMHP	13	8%	69%	8%	8%	0%	0%
DPPE	86	21%	62%	14%	1%	0%	0%
A18776W1	**1**						
DPPE	1						
Political Thought: Bentham to Weber	**16**						
A12733W1	**16**						
DMHP	2						
DPPE	14	43%	57%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau	**13**						

A12732W1	**13**						
DMHP	4						
DPPE	9	22%	78%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in China	**11**	**27%**	**73%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
A12743W1	**11**	**27%**	**73%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
DPPE	11	27%	73%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in Europe	**7**	**14%**	**43%**	**43%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
A12723W1	**7**	**14%**	**43%**	**43%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
DPPE	7	14%	43%	43%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in Latin America	**7**	**14%**	**71%**	**0%**	**14%**	**0%**	**0%**
A12726W1	**7**	**14%**	**71%**	**0%**	**14%**	**0%**	**0%**
DPPE	7	14%	71%	0%	14%	0%	0%
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union	**16**						
A12724W1	**16**						
DMHP	5						
DPPE	11	18%	82%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in South Asia	**9**						
A12727W1	**9**						
DMHP	3						
DPPE	6	33%	67%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa	**21**						
A12725W1	**21**						
DMHP	5						
DPPE	16	25%	63%	6%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in the Middle East	**22**	**45%**	**55%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
A12728W1	**22**	**45%**	**55%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
DMHP	7	57%	43%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	15	40%	60%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Social Policy	**34**						

A12740W1	**34**						
DMHP	5						
DPPE	29	17%	69%	14%	0%	0%	0%
Sociological Theory	**20**						
A12735W1	**20**						
DMHP	1						
DPPE	19	26%	53%	21%	0%	0%	0%
Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory	**22**						
A17606W1	**22**						
DMHP	2						
DPPE	20	25%	65%	5%	0%	0%	0%
Special Subject in Politics: International Security and Conflict	**46**	**28%**	**63%**	**4%**	**2%**	**0%**	**0%**
A15594W1	**46**	**28%**	**63%**	**4%**	**2%**	**0%**	**0%**
DMHP	8	25%	63%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	38	29%	63%	5%	3%	0%	0%
The Politics of the European Union	**7**						
A12744W1	**7**						
DMHP	2						
DPPE	5						
Theory of Politics	**120**						
A15005W1	**119**	**25%**	**66%**	**8%**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
DMHP	25	24%	64%	8%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	94	26%	67%	7%	0%	0%	0%
A15005X1	**1**						
DPPE	1						
Thesis in Politics	**26**	**31%**	**54%**	**12%**	**0%**	**0%**	**4%**
A12746S1	**26**	**31%**	**54%**	**12%**	**0%**	**0%**	**4%**
DMHP	6	0%	83%	0%	0%	0%	17%
DPPE	20	40%	45%	15%	0%	0%	0%

Grand Total	**952**	**26%**	**60%**	**11%**	**1%**	**0%**	**0%**

Report on A15005W1 Theory of Politics (taken as a Politics paper)

122 Candidates took the exam. 97 PPE candidates and 25 HP candidates.

Question	Number of Answers
1	57
2	35
3	32
4	40
5	24
6	6
7	14
8	49
9	8
10	24
11	6
12	8

Question 1. 'Non-interference is necessary but not sufficient for liberty.' Discuss. (57 answers)

The most popular question. Candidates generally did well at identifying arguments for non-interference being insufficient for liberty, and there were some good discussions of those arguments, both supportive and critical. Weaker answers failed to consider whether non-interference was in fact necessary for liberty, including some that claimed to agree with the statement in the question while defending conceptions of freedom that seemed to make non-interference unnecessary. The strongest answers showed a sophisticated understanding of various aspects of the debate over conceptions of liberty, and many provided a persuasive defence of the candidate's favoured conception.

Question 2. 'One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman.' (DE BEAUVOIR) What are the implications of this claim for political theory? (35 answers)

This question was generally well-answered, with candidates thoughtfully exploring what the implications of the idea of the social construction of gender might be for political theory. Some strong answers showed good knowledge of De Beauvoir's own views, with a few even using this to challenge conventional interpretations of the quotation. But this certainly wasn't necessary for a strong answer, many of which presented the candidate's own interpretation of the claim in order to then discuss its implications, drawing well on contemporary feminist literature. Weaker answers tended toward listing various implications without sufficient nuance or any unified analysis.

3. Can there be an obligation to obey an unjust law? (32 answers)

A reasonably popular question, although it attracted fewer answers than questions on political obligation often do, perhaps because it was a reasonably difficult question. Some candidates struggled to find any reason there might be an obligation to obey an unjust law. As is common with this topic, some could not resist the temptation to simply run through various accounts of political

obligation and report their answer to the question. Better answers recognised that injustice might come in degrees, and discussed arguments (e.g. from Rawls) for obligations to obey at least those that were not too unjust. Some also drew helpfully on the civil disobedience literature.

4. 'Justice and injustice are institutional problems with institutional solutions.' Discuss. (40 answers)

The third most population question. The question has several aspects, since it refers to both justice and injustice and to the nature of both the problems and the solutions. The best answers deftly handled this complexity, including some interesting arguments for why one of the problem or solution is institutional while the other is not. Most answers discussed Cohen's critique of Rawls, but candidates also drew helpfully on other literatures, such as those on structural and racial injustice.

5. 'The exercise of power is not simply a relationship between partners, individual or collective; it is a way in which certain actions modify others.' (FOUCAULT) Discuss. (24 answers)

Candidates generally showed good knowledge of Foucault's account of power and how it differed from accounts focused on a relationship between agents (especially Lukes's account). Weaker answers did less well at tying this discussion to the specific quotation and/or presented this material rather uncritically. Better answers considered weaknesses as well as strengths of Foucault's account, and some made interesting for suggestions of how we might combine the two kinds of account.

6. What kinds of facts, if any, should constrain the prescriptions of political theorists? (6 answers)

Relatively few answers. Candidates drew well on various aspects of the literature for this topic – including Cohen's view of fact-insensitivity, debates about feasibility, and realist approaches – and discussed various kinds of facts that might be relevant to the question. It was important for this question to focus on how those facts constrain political theorists' prescriptions, in particular.

7. 'Socialist criticisms of capitalism are more plausible than socialist proposals for its replacement.' Discuss. (14 answers)

Strong answers considered several socialist traditions and both their critiques and proposals. Even when they agreed with the prompt, strong answers considered whether plausible proposals consistent with socialism might be available. Weaker answers tended toward simply presenting literature reviews.

8. 'Any compelling conception of egalitarianism must take account of both fairness and respect.' Discuss. (49 answers)

A popular question (the second most popular), which prompted some thoughtful answers regarding the way considerations of both fairness and respect factor into egalitarianism. Most candidates agreed with the statement, but there was a wide range of views on what kind of conception of egalitarianism this led to. Standard answers tended to simply say that distributive and relational equality both matter, with some tending toward simply presenting a literature review. Stronger answers offered a deeper analysis, including some that argued that one of either distributive or relational egalitarianism could adequately capture both fairness and respect. Some good answers also disagreed with the statement in the question.

9. To what extent, and in what ways (if any), should current human rights practice constrain our understanding of human rights? (8 answers)

Few answers, and not very well answered by those who attempted it. The question points toward the debate between 'philosophical' and 'political' conceptions of human rights, but candidates seemed unfamiliar with that debate. This meant answers tended not to have much of a sense of what it would mean for human rights practice to constrain our understanding of human rights, or of why this might be an attractive or unattractive proposal.

10. 'Deliberative democracy is too utopian an ideal to be helpful in real-world politics.' Discuss. (24 answers)

Candidates generally showed good knowledge of various critiques of deliberative democracy, especially in the idealised form presented by theorists such as Joshua Cohen. Better answers involved interesting arguments regarding whether such an ideal can nonetheless be helpful in real-world politics and/or drew upon less idealised accounts of deliberative democracy to argue for its practical relevance, including through institutions such as mini-publics.

11. Are there any inequalities that libertarians should not accept? (6 answers)

Few answers, which broadly divided into weak and strong. The weaker answers tended to simply survey libertarian reasons for tolerating inequality while neglecting libertarian grounds for objecting to it. Certain stronger answers engaged the matter of justice in acquisition and explored left-libertarian views. There were a couple of excellent responses that offered sophisticated discussion of the relationship between inequality and meaningful self-ownership.

12. Is the secular state tolerant? (8 answers)

Another less popular question. Those who attempted the question drew well on various aspects of the literature both on secularism specifically and multiculturism more generally. The best answers thought carefully both about what it means for the state to be secular and what it means for it to be tolerant.

Report on A12704W1 Theory of Politics (taken as a Philosophy paper)

Note

Normally the Theory of Politics paper is identical for students taking it as a Philosophy paper versus students taking it as a Politics paper. This year because of exceptional circumstances, the papers were different. However, the questions were set according to the same syllabus. Below are comments on the Philosophy version of the paper.

General comments

The quality of student answers this year was pretty good. Students were generally well-versed in the literature, and were happy to even draw on literature outside of the required reading list. Students also did a pretty good job, albeit with room for improvement, when it came to critically assessing these arguments. The very best answers excelled when it came to critical assessment – with a critical commentary that zoomed-in on one particular (potential) flaw with an argument being discussed, as well as discussion of how proponents of the argument being criticised might respond to said criticism.

In terms of what might be improved, I would reiterate that while breadth of knowledge is impressive, it should not come at the expense of depth of critical discussion. The main thing I would encourage future students to add to their work, is more in-depth critical assessment of the argument(s) being discussed, even if this means limiting the number of arguments being discussed. Here are three specific ways that one can try to make one's work feature impressive, in-depth critical discussion.

First, students could focus on one specific flaw in the argument being discussed. Students consistently discussed objections to arguments. But what would elevate this kind of discussion, would be some commentary on e.g., which specific premise is being pressured, which presupposition, which leap of logic, which empirical assumption, etc. Students can also seek to carefully distinguish the objection they are discussing, from a similar but distinct objection. Again you can imagine how this might involve some commentary on which premise or leap of logic is being attacked by the objection the student is most interested in. This is a good way of adding nuance and precision to one's answers.

Second, objections to an argument really should be followed by some commentary on how a proponent of the argument might try and respond to this objection. Students can then, of course, discuss whether these responses are convincing – again providing the student with an opportunity to add nuance to their discussion, as well as allowing their own voice to really come through on the page.

Third, I remind students that it is better to discuss just one objection in excellent depth (see above), rather than two or three objections in less impressive depth. To be fair, this is difficult, and doubly so under exam conditions. But I would encourage students to try their best to slow down when planning their answers, and see if there is a specific objection that they can discuss in good depth.

Notes on specific questions

1. **Are disagreements over the concept of liberty simply moral disagreements dressed up as conceptual ones?**

A popular question. Students discussed Berlin on positive and negative freedom, as well as republican accounts of freedom as non-domination. Stronger answered sought to clearly define moral disagreements v conceptual disagreements. Weaker answers defined these terms in a sloppy manner, or failed to really define them at all.

In terms of how to improve, students would do well, when comparing different accounts to consider not only their differing verdicts on cases, but also how these differing verdicts stem from distinctive lines of argument/reasoning. In addition, many students discussed Berlin's worry that positive accounts of freedom tend to be used to unjustifiably coerce agents (e.g., in the name of helping those free themselves from false consciousness and/or agents actualising their higher self). But, somewhat surprisingly, few students commented on whether this was a merely pragmatic worry with positive accounts, or whether it reflected a more conceptual error.

2. **Is feminism best understood as a doctrine of equal rights?**

Another popular question. Lots of students discussed philosophers like MacKinnon and Okin. Lots of answered construed 'a doctrine of equal rights' as essentially about equal legal rights, and then went on to discuss how feminist accounts go beyond demanding equal legal rights. Again, students would have benefitted from going beyond comparing differing conclusions, and instead focusing on comparing different arguments/lines of reasoning. Some interesting answers revolved around discussing, essentially, how de jure legal rights should not be the sole goal of a political utopia. Rather, we should also strive for, and feminists have long said this, social conditions where citizens can easily utilise these legal rights. This was a good move and led to fruitful discussion.

3. **'Philosophical anarchists believe that we should obey the law, and so their rejection of political obligation is illusory.' Discuss.**

Students discussed, among other philosophers, Rawls, Hobbes, Hume, and Wolff. All of these are fine philosophers to discuss, but weaker answers tended to discuss too many different accounts, skimming over key details, and running out of time to properly critically engage with the materials discussed. Rawls, in particular, tended to be described in an inaccurate manner. In addition, some key parts of the political anarchist argument went under-examined. For instance, if political anarchists think we should obey the law because the alternative would be a brutish state of nature, yet don't believe this is a political obligation, it is important for the student to carefully explain why the benefits conferred to citizens by the state do not establish a political obligation. Do they establish a different kind of obligation? Or do they just establish non-obligatory reasons to obey the government?

4. **'The basic structure of society is the primary subject of justice because its effects are so profound and present from the start.' (RAWLS) Discuss.**

A question that students generally could have answered much better. The main problem was a lack of precision and care when discussing Rawls. The strongest answers didn't necessarily discuss lots of Rawls' ideas or arguments. But they did carefully unpack at least one line of argument. Another issue is that a couple students took 'present from the start' to refer to 'the start of Rawls' original position

thought experiment', which I don't think is what the question is getting at. I also remind students that it is important, when critiquing a philosopher, to consider how they might respond so as to defend their view from this critique.

5. **'Power is exercised only over free subjects, and only insofar as they are "free"' (FOUCAULT). Discuss.**

Students answered this question by discussing Foucault, Arendt, and Young. That said, too many students fell into the trap of giving a superficial critique, roughly of the form 'he says X, but she says Y'. It isn't that interesting or impressive to merely compare two different accounts. Indeed, when it comes to how two philosophers provide different accounts of power, one needs to be mindful that these philosophers may simply be talking past one another – using the same word to describe distinct concepts. A much better approach, then, is to think about how the insights of one philosopher's can be used to develop a direct critique of another philosopher's work. A good tip is to think about how the work of one philosopher can be developed to pressure a particular assumption or argumentative move in another philosopher's work.

6. **'Infeasible political ideals are ultimately worthless.' Discuss.**

Not the most popular question, but a question that was answered rather well. The strongest answered differentiated between subtly different meanings of 'infeasible'. As some students pointed out, most highly idealised political visions are not literally infeasible in the sense of being beyond the capacity of humans to create. So 'infeasible' may be denoting a more subtle kind of difficulty with securing a political vision. In addition, some good answered explored the idea that while infeasible political ideals may be limited in their worth, they nonetheless can provide certain particular insights that do have some worth/function.

7. **Does tackling racial injustice require anything more than the consistent application of liberal theories of justice?**

Students discussed the work of Rawls, Shelby, and Mills. Answered tended to consider either Rawls' liberal view, or some kind of consent and legal rights-based view, before following this up with a discussion of how Shelby or Mills have critiqued these accounts. There were some nice suggestions about how, even in a liberal society where citizens have a full gamut of legal rights, things like internalised negative stereotypes can impede flourishing. A few students pushed the idea that a problem with liberal theories is that while folk who have internalised racist stereotypes and now sit on hiring boards, may end up discriminating against black candidates. But isn't this the kind of discrimination that liberal theories can in fact comfortably label as unjust? Though, perhaps, there is a related worry about how this kind of subtle discrimination can be hard to detect and stop.

8. **Does socialism rely on an unrealistically optimistic view of human nature?**

All answers to this question discussed Cohen. Indeed, this was a rather well-answered question – perhaps because students took their time in digging into the details of Cohen's arguments. The best answered identified and distinguished specific ways in which a view can be 'unrealistically optimistic', before launching into a discussion of Cohen's understanding of human nature falls into this trap. A particularly good answer distinguished between a few ways of understanding the idea that humans are too selfish – they generally prioritise their own interests, they always pick their own interests over the interests of others, certain ways of flourishing require self-orientated goods to be secured.

This led to a granular discussion of the extent to which Cohen's work allows for these different kinds of selfishness.

9. 'Distributive equality and relational equality complement one another, rather than conflict with one another.' Discuss.

Again, I would remind students not to simply compare the conclusions of different accounts, but to discuss which one is correct – or, at least, discuss how one account might be used to target an assumption or leap of logic in another account. For instance, when discussing how relational accounts like the one espoused by Anderson, versus luck egalitarian accounts, it important to consider not only the way the conclusions of these accounts conflict, but also reasoning that underwrites this conflict. Sure, folk like Dworkin think that goods can be distributed unevenly when this is the result of people making poor choices for themselves. And this may mean that his conclusions are different to Anderson's – with Anderson being interested in our status in society and insisting that citizens be able to relate to one another as equals. But why the different conclusions? Why does/might Anderson think that citizens must be able to relate to each other as equals, even if this means (so to speak) rewarding people's poor choices? One particularly interesting answered considered whether relational equality deflates into some sophisticated version of distributive equality. This set the stage for an interesting discussion of whether there is something about relational equality that makes it distinctively valuable.

10. Does the best account of human rights appeal to distinctively human capacities?

Too few answers on this question for me to give substantial feedback. One confusion that did creep in to the answers that were given, involved conflating i) capacities that all humans have, and ii) capacities that only humans have.

11. How much economic equality (if any) is required for democracy?

Students provided rather good answers to this question. The strongest answers discussed some democratic value and the ways that economic inequality threaten this value. Students did a good job of carefully distinguishing between intrinsic and instrumental values, as well as how some threats totally undermine our values, while others leave us with a diminished version of that value. There was also some nice commentary on how the legal right to vote can be distinguished from citizens actually voting/being motivated to vote, as well as citizens voting in a way that reflects their interests.

In terms of how to improve, students made some sloppy conflations. Inequality is not the same as some folk being destitute. Obviously these thing can be related, but it is a bit sloppy to take the former to straightforwardly imply the latter. Similarly, a lack of income does not imply a lack of education.

12. 'Global government necessary for global justice.' Discuss.

Too few students answered this question, for me to provide feedback.

Report on A12719W1 Comparative Government

Questions	Number of Answers
1	18
2	6
3	34
4	16
5	4
6	21
7	5
8	31
9	6
10	5
11	23
12	2

No questions were reported during the exam and the overall quality of answers was high. The average score was 66. The average score across all questions was similar.

The report turns to comments from examiners on questions where specific weaker answers were noted or questions where commendably strong answers were presented with guidance on what contributed to stronger answers. The commentary of a question here (or lack thereof) has no bearing on whether the topic will appear on future iterations of the exam.

Question 1. Good answers first needed to present a definition of a clientelistic parties and citizens, and give illustrative examples of 'gifts and favours,' as well as define the terms 'brokers' and 'core'. Better answers could draw on empirical studies from regions, ideally beyond just Latin America, but good answers discussing just Latina America data in depth were possible. Discussion of alternative findings (such as 'swing' voters) and the importance of voter turnout were important for a quality answer.

Question 3. Strong answers went beyond merely disagreeing with the prompt and classified explanations as to why the prompt might be incorrect. Answers considered alternative implications and reasons why autocracies might adopt democratic institutions with consideration of arguments in Svolik, Levitsky and Way, Gandhi, and other required readings. Better answers classified and went into detail as to whether different types of democratic institutions may have different implications.

Question 6. Answers needed to provide some definitions of each of the term in the prompt and give examples historically. Engagement with arguments and evidence from Tilly was important to the answer. Answers could also refer to Bates and Spruyt. Subtle answers questioned whether the prompt was providing a definition of a state, or whether was making an argument about what brings about states versus other forms of political organizations, or whether the notion of 'weak' vs 'strong' state was relevant.

Question 8. Answers need not engage all explanations from the reading list, but choices of explanations needed to be justified. An answer merely regurgitating one or a few explanations of democratization without discussion of whether the phenomenon is overdetermined was weaker. Answers that either interpreted 'systematic' as related to systems-based explanations, or 'systematic' as meaning singular explanation were accepted as long as the decision was articulated and minimally justified. Strong answers considered democratization in different regional and historical contexts.

Strong answers could argue that the persuasiveness of multiple explanations means the prompt is correct, but would then argue more concretely why this is the case.

Question 11. Strong answers defined and justified the focus on specific outcomes, such as economic development and democracy. A subset of factors from the reading list was acceptable as long as this choice was acknowledged. Engagement with Acemoglu, Robinson, and related readings about colonial institutions was essential. Strong answers considered multiple areas of former colonies. Strong answers needed to directly grapple with arguments about which institutions would have effects that would or would not be 'persistent.' Subtle answers pointed to which types of outcomes might be easier to assess from an inferential perspective.

Report on A12720W1 British Politics and Government since 1900

The choice of questions by PPE and HP candidates was broadly similar. It was, however, after a broadening last year, even more heavily concentrated than usual on a small number of questions. The question-setters are part of the cause of this. But candidates should reflect on whether they will show themselves to best advantage by tackling a question for which they are ill-prepared, even it is on a familiar topic. Among the more popular questions, there were - as there have been for many years - some answers which suggested candidates were indeed ill-prepared, whether because they were unfamiliar with the academic writing on the area of focus, or with the whole of the assigned historical period, or with the terms in the question.

The cheering thing about this concentration is that, at the top end, the best candidates are writing essays of very considerable sophistication on these topics, presumably because the concentration of preparation on them leaves them ready for almost any question. The dismaying thing is that other candidates, unable or unwilling to pivot to answer an unfamiliar question, neglect to mention the academic writing, leave out half the historical period, and ignore the terms in the question.

1. What part did socialist ideas play in the origins and growth of the Labour Party? (25 answers).

This was a popular question which attracted some well-informed and thoughtful answers. The best answers provided clear definitions of socialist ideas, paying due attention to their considerable diversity. They also distinguished these as causes of Labour's origins and growth from other possible explanations, both ideas that were not socialist, and causes that were not ideas. Most answers were stronger on 'origins' than they were on 'growth' and some did not distinguish between the two. Some answers would have gained from attention to the ways (mechanisms, processes, institutions) through which socialist ideas were made influential (where they were).

2. Was the Liberal Party in decline before the First World War? (25 answers).

Another very popular question. Stronger answers defined 'decline' and gave some thought to different types of 'decline' and how they could be measured and judged. They also showed awareness of the persistence of disagreement on this question among political historians, and why these historians differ. The challenge of the Labour Party usually got more attention than the revival of the Conservatives and Unionists, and this choice was not always justified. Some candidates took their answers too far into the First World War, and even beyond, which usually meant a loss of focus on the question asked.

3. Why was the Conservative and Unionist Party so opposed to Home Rule for Ireland? (8 answers).

Not many answers for this question, but most were very good, drawing out both the 'Westminster' and 'Ireland' aspects, and considering ideological, constitutional, religious, electoral, economic, imperial, and numerous other angles of analysis. The weaker answers tended to over-broaden the question into explaining the intractability of 'the Irish Question' as a whole, thereby losing focus on the question of Conservative and Unionist policy. It was, of course, permissible to question the assumption that the party was 'so opposed'.

4. Did the women's suffrage movement have feminist goals besides the winning of votes for women? (12 answers).

A few candidates addressed the question closely, but others were hoping for another sort of question about women's suffrage, and focused too much on the debate over militancy and the relationships with political parties. Here, as elsewhere, definitions were important: 'feminist goals' were not always clearly defined (or defined at all). The possibility that 'feminist goals' beyond the vote were present, sometimes powerfully present, but were set aside in the interests of unity in the suffrage movement, and attracting wider support beyond it, was usefully proposed by some candidates.

5. Why was it impossible to reconstruct the Liberal and Labour Progressive Alliance in the 1920s? (0 answers).

No one answered this question. It is worth future candidates thinking about it, though, because besides its intrinsic interest, it offers a way of reflecting on the nature of the Alliance when it existed.

6. Why did so many people vote Conservative in the 1930s? (5 answers).

Few answers to this question, and they were quite a mix. The stronger ones knew the literature well, and offered precise formulations of the causes, providing plausible evidence where it existed, and also noting the weaknesses of the evidence, especially of electoral behaviour. They also spotted that part of the answer lies beyond the Conservative Party (that is elsewhere in the party system). The weaker ones 'over-explained' - as though everyone voted Conservative in the 1930s - or offered simple generalizations, such as the 'deference' of working-class voters, the conservatism of women voters, the universal appeal of Baldwin's leadership, the effects of first-past-the-post, etc.

7. Did Labour win power in 1945 because of class politics, or despite class politics? (52 answers).

Practically everyone had a go at this question. The weaker answers took it just to be asking why Labour won in 1945 and offered more or less well-informed answers to this staple question. Better answers focused more sharply on 'class politics' as a factor in the victory. Some candidates declined to 'pick a card' and argued, often with sophistication, that Labour won some votes because of class politics, and other votes despite it. Few candidates, though, moved beyond 'working-class' and 'middle-class' as the best way to understand 'class', and this weakened the analysis, especially when those categories were defined too simply (all the working-class in industrial work and trade unions, for example).

8. Is the best explanation of British decolonization that British governments cared more about retaining global influence than remaining a colonial power? (4 answers).

Too few answers to this question to permit much comment. A good response needed to appreciate the distinction between having 'global influence' and 'being a colonial power', so candidates who thought that the two were much the same thing were in a poor position to answer.

9. Did Britain have a crisis of governability in the 1970s? If so, why? (11 answers).

Most candidates thought Britain did have a crisis of governability in the 1970s, although defining 'governability', and indeed 'crisis' (crisis? what crisis?) would have improved some of their answers.

So also would distinguishing problems of 'governability' from other types of problem – e.g. party disunity, ineffective leadership, economic problems besides those of 'governing the economy'. Weaker answers also tended to be miserabilist – finding every aspect of political life in the 1970s to indicate crisis – or focused just on the winter of 1978-79. As regards causes, there was a range of sophistication: from some answers which were rigorous and precise, especially about the economic causes of 'ungovernability', to others which described the crisis, sometimes in semi-apocalyptic terms, but did not really explain it.

10. What, if anything, did the Conservatism of the 1980s have in common with the Conservatism of earlier decades? (48 answers).

Another very popular question. Most candidates had a lot to say, and in some cases, that weakened their answers because what they said had to be rushed and hence over-simplified. Better candidates were also careful about the difference between Conservatism and the Conservative Party (and also between both those and the Thatcher Governments, the 'Thatcherites', and Mrs Thatcher). Weaker candidates were not so careful, and used these terms indiscriminately or even interchangeably. The term 'earlier decades' in the question left room for choice, but here too precision was important, as was making informed comparisons which were also sensitive to differences in the political context.

11. Is New Labour best understood as an attempt by social democrats to respond to a critique made by the New Right? (42 answers).

Another very popular question. The question was specific, offering a single interpretation for candidates to consider. The good candidates - of whom there were many - engaged with this, and their answers were usually marked by a willingness to leave some things out in order to achieve a fuller engagement with it. The answers themselves were varied: some candidates thought that New Labour was illuminated by thinking of it as a response to the New Right; others (probably more of them) thought that it was better understood as a rethinking of the social democratic tradition in response to the perceived non-viability of its older forms, for which the New Right critique was a sideshow. Weaker candidates, for the most part, did not engage with any of this, offering their own understanding of New Labour without reference to the interpretation in the question.

12. Did 'Brexit' create a new dimension in British electoral politics? (5 answers)

Very few answers here, so, again, not much scope for comment. The critical word in the question is 'dimension'. Good candidates recognised this and were aware of the scholarly literature, especially the quantitative work, which discusses it. This was not a question which should have prompted general reflections on Brexit's effects on the political world of today.

Report on A12721W1 Modern British Government and Politics

Questions	Number of Answers
1	8
2	3
3	8
4	6
5	3
6	7
7	3
8	4
9	5
10	7
11	1
12	2

1. To what extent is it feasible to clarify the workings of the UK's uncodified constitution through documents such as the Cabinet Manual? (8 answers).

Some excellent analyses of the scope and importance of the Cabinet Manual, which in the better answers were tightly related to the long-standing question of how the uncodified constitution works. Weaker answers got too quickly to the long-standing question, and offered over-general reflections on the nature of the uncodified constitution. Some candidates usefully reflected on why the Cabinet Manual (or other documents) do not do more to clarify.

2. 'Brexit has reclaimed parliamentary sovereignty, but at a cost to the UK's international standing and ability to cooperate effectively with other democratic nations.' Discuss. (3 answers).

There were a lot of claims packed into this question, but a good answer unpacked them carefully, thinking about what exactly was meant by each of the terms, considering how the claims could be judged, and weighing the evidence for and against. Weaker answers were those in which this was done with less care for precision and evidence.

3. Has the development of the Cabinet Office into a more active executive department in recent years made the UK Prime Minister too powerful? (8 answers).

Some excellent answers to this question, which were up-to-speed about the evolution of the Cabinet Office, and thoughtful about the effect this had had on Prime Ministerial power. Some candidates were reflective about what it means for the Cabinet Office to be more 'active', and indeed for the Prime Minister to be '(too) powerful' – both how these claims can be measured, and also how, and by what standards, they should be judged normatively.

4. 'The essence of good governance is not just efficiency, but accountability to the public.' How well have the reform strategies of recent UK governments, such as the 2012 Civil Service Reform plan, addressed this concern? (6 answers).

Some very well-informed answers to this question, especially on the complex detail of civil service reform. The better answers were those that focused more on the accountability problem, rather than broadly on the success and failures of the reforms; and the best of all were those that interrogated the idea of 'accountability to the public', distinguishing it from (for example) accountability to ministers, watchdogs, parliamentary commissions, etc; and explained why it is hard to achieve. One candidate usefully distinguished between 'public service', which they thought had improved, and 'accountability to the public'., which they thought hadn't.

5. Does the First-Past-The-Post electoral system ensure that British politics will remain primarily a two-party system? (3 answers).

A mix of answers to this question, which was more precisely focused than the perhaps more familiar question about the nature of the relationship between electoral and party systems. Good answers showed a high level of sophistication in analysing the complex workings of first-past-the-post in recent UK parliamentary elections. They also examined what remaining 'primarily' a two party system meant; with one arguing that even Westminster – let alone those bodies elected using other electoral systems – was no longer 'primarily' two-party.

6. 'The House of Lords remains a bastion of unearned privilege and an anomaly in a modern democracy.' Do you agree? (7 answers).

Lots of words to define in this question, and the better answers were careful and precise in doing so. There were several cases for the defence, and the better of these examined the 'modern democracy' case for a specialist, less partisan chamber, and either contested the claim concerning unearned privilege, or asserted its irrelevance to the working of the House of Lords. The word 'remains' in the question invited candidates to think about the present functioning of the Lords, and how it is currently changing. The good candidates were up-to-date about this, some making good use of the available documentary material.

7. Has the influence of media on UK politics undermined democratic principles, or enhanced transparency and accountability since the time of the Leveson Inquiry? (3 answers).

Some thoughtful responses to this question, although answers were sometimes weakened by imprecision about the influence of the media on UK politics: what it is, how to measure it. Good answers were often those which refused the choice posed in the question, e.g. in suggesting that the results of Leveson (and other changes) have been mixed; also those which explored what democratic principles were at stake, and what (and whose) transparency and accountability might or might not have been enhanced.

8. 'In the shadows of democracy, interest groups and elite connections shape policy far more than the electorate.' Discuss with reference to the UK's response to the Covid-19 crisis. (4 answers).

A difficult question, because a good answer here needed both to be familiar with the academic literature on interest groups and policymaking networks, and also with the detail of the UK's policy response to Covid-19 which is, of course, still emerging. It was worthwhile for candidates to consider how the electorate shapes government policy between elections, or is meant to do so, directly or indirectly, in or out of the 'shadows of democracy'.

9. Does the principle of parliamentary sovereignty inevitably undermine the role of the judiciary in upholding constitutional structures and human rights? (5 answers).

This was a question which could be approached more empirically or more theoretically; and much turned on how candidates chose to interpret 'inevitably' and 'undermine'. Some candidates were thoughtful, and well-informed, about the academic debates concerning the meaning of parliamentary sovereignty and how it may or may not be attentive to constitutional and rights-based concerns. Others were equally thoughtful, and well-informed, about recent tensions between parliament, government and the higher judiciary, and sometimes sceptical about whether it is 'the principle of parliamentary sovereignty' that best explains them.

10. 'Devolution has sown the seeds of the United Kingdom's disintegration.' Evaluate this statement in light of the UK government's invocation of Section 35 of the Scotland Act in January 2023. (7 answers).

Some very good answers to this question, the best of which were thoughtful about what 'disintegration' meant, and how it should be measured and judged. Here, as elsewhere, a very good knowledge of the development of recent events was shown. In some cases, however, the level of detail provided could crowd out space for analysis.

11. Has Brexit been a litmus test for democracy, revealing the fundamentally popular foundations of the constitution, or merely a populist misadventure? (1 answer).

Too few answers for comment.

12. To what extent, and with what results, have British political parties become more ideological and less pragmatic since 2010? (2 answers).

Too few answers to provide scope for comment; but perhaps it is worth observing that asking whether parties have become more 'ideological' is not the same as asking if they have moved to the right or left; also that parties are complex organizations, some parts of which may be more or less 'ideological' than others.

Report on A12722W1 Government and Politics in the United States

Questions	Number of Answers
1	9
2	2
3	6
4	5
5	9
6	14
7	0
8	8
9	6
10	0
11	6
12	7

As can be seen there was a wide spread of answers, although regrettably little interest in federalism, policy making, or constitutionalism. As so often the most popular answers were on Congress and on the Presidency, though candidates often did better on their answers on other topics.

Notes on specific questions:

1. Some good answers here, taking up the question of whether exceptionalism should be thought of as a hypothesis. Weaker answers just discussed exceptionalism in general, and a few seemed unsure about what "falsifiable" means.

3. and 4. Generally solidly answered, although some candidates struggled to operationalise "weak" or identify political consequences of voter polarisation.

5. Answers were exceptionally well informed, in particular about the House, although some missed the opportunity to discuss the Senate. Generally the problem was identifying what constituted power in legislative leadership in ways that distinguished it from representation of the caucus.

6. If there was a weakness here it was lack of engagement with the question; many answers showed good knowledge of the literature but some didn't show much sense of what the question might mean by "unilaterally".

8. Some excellent answers here addressing the problem of measuring influence; a few were persuaded that the sugar study solved this for all interest groups, but most were critically engaged with the interests literature and had good examples of why the question was a problem.

9. Again some great answers here. The best showed an awareness that "policy seeking" might be affected by time-frame and focus; what was best in the short term or in some policy areas might not be best in the long term or across others.

11. Some well informed answers here although candidates didn't have much to say about the question of racial polarisation of American voters (and whether this is changing over time).

12. Candidates generally agreed with this statement, although often their focus on social media was not accompanied by an argument about whether that represented *national* media.

Report on A12723W1 Politics in Europe

7 PPE candidates took the Exam. There were no HP candidates.

Question	Number of Answers
1	1
2	3
3	1
4	2
5	4
6	0
7	0
8	1
9	5
10	3
11	0
12	1

There were seven scripts of which one was excellent, one script was a high 2.1, and five scripts achieved a grade of 65 or below.

The quality of individual answers was generally high.

Out of the 12 questions, nine questions attracted at least one answer, and three questions received no attempts. The detailed question breakdown is as follows:

Specific notes on questions with a substantial number of answers:

9 This question was answered by five students. The best answers provided a theoretically informed discussion of the dilemmas faced by coalitions and a comprehensive and critical evaluation of the mechanisms that multi-party governments in various European states employ to address such dilemmas, including detailed and relevant references to current and classic contributions to this field.

Report on A12724W1 Politics of Russia in the Former Soviet Union

16 candidates took the exam in Trinity Term 2024: 11 PPE students and 5 HPol students. The standard was average for an undergrad script. Final marks ranged from 57 to 75, with an overall average of 66. Three candidates achieved a First-Class mark.

Question	Number of Answers
1	2
2	9
3	3
4	7
5	1
6	4
7	3
8	5
9	5
10	3
11	1
12	5

Frequency of responses: low (up to 4); middle (5 to 8); high (more than 8).

Question 1. How does competitive authoritarianism influence political dynamics in former Soviet states? (Low) = 2

Few candidates answered this question. Both scripts demonstrated a very strong understanding of the existing debates around authoritarianism in Political Science, especially within the former Soviet space. It noteworthy that both students who answered Question 1 also achieved the top two grades (75 and 74) on the exam.

Question 2. 'The collapse of the Soviet Union was not the consequence of Mikhail Gorbachev's perestroika, but national revolutions.' Discuss. (High) = 9

This question was the most frequently answered. The stronger scripts engaged with the competing debates about Gorbachev's perestroika, including the ideological underpinnings of his motivations and the shortcomings of his reforms. They also showed an awareness of the large literature around national mobilizations and revolutions across the Soviet Union in the 1980s and early 1990s. The weaker scripts had unclear arguments or were quite descriptive rather than analytical. The marks widely ranged from 58-78.

Question 3. Can all post-Soviet protests be classified as revolutions? (Low) = 3

Few candidates answered this question. The answers did a decent job engaging with literature on revolutions, protests, and mobilizations. They also explained what the colour revolutions were, and why and how they occurred, as well as detailed their varied outcomes across the former Soviet space. The strongest of the three answers drew on comparative examples and explained whether

(and why) the era of revolutions in the post-Soviet states may not yet be 'over.' The marks for this question were above average and ranged from 65-78.

Question 4. 'Corruption in former Soviet states is the result of weak executives.' Discuss. (Middle) = 7

This question produced both very strong and weak answers. The strongest analysed executives comparatively across the post-Soviet space and included specific cases and examples of where corruption has and has not dominated domestic politics. They also engaged with the large body of literature on corruption within the former Soviet space. Several of the weaker scripts were quite descriptive and lacked a coherent argument. The marks for this question ranged from 58-78.

Question 5. Are there more similarities than differences in the origins of protest in the former Soviet states? (Low) = 1

One candidate answered this question. Still, it is noteworthy that none of the students who answered Question 3 also answered this one, despite the potential for overlap. The single essay received a mark of 68.

Question 6. How do dominant parties influence politics in the former Soviet states? (Low) = 4

Few candidates answered this question. Overall, the answers to this question were quite weak and only minimally engaged with the literature about the role of political parties in the former Soviet space. Some of the answers lacked a coherent argument and did not provide effectively answer how dominant parties influence politics in the former Soviet region. The marks for this question were below average and ranged from 55-65.

Question 7. Are international or domestic factors more important for explaining hybrid regimes in former Soviet states? (Low) = 4

The answers to this question varied considerably and included both very strong and weak answers. Some did a good job laying out a clear argument and explaining the role of both international and domestic factors in hybrid regimes. Others failed to make sound arguments and were very descriptive in their analyses. The marks assigned to the essays ranged from 55-73.

Question 8. To what extent has nationalism sustained regimes since the collapse of the USSR? (Low) = 4

A small number of candidates answered this question. The scripts generally examined the existing theories around civic and ethnic understandings of nationalism, and the roles of each within the former Soviet states. Some of the stronger essays also examined the different drivers of nationalist mobilisation during the Soviet period. When doing so, many answers also compared nationalist mobilisations in different republics to highlight variation in the role of nationalism, especially between the Baltics and Central Asia. The assigned marks were above average and ranged from 65-78.

Question 9. Does the rigidity of presidentialism explain political outcomes in former Soviet states? (Middle) = 5

Approximately a third of all candidates answered this question. The stronger essays comparatively examined the role of the president in domestic politics in the former Soviet states, demonstrating where presidentialism has proven to be more and less rigid across the region. The stronger essays also included a variety of examples and drew on the extensive existing literature. The weaker essays were quite descriptive and failed to effectively answer the question. The assigned grades were overall lower than average and ranged from 52-68.

Question 10. What explains variation in the dependency of former Soviet economies on natural resources? (Low) = 3

Few candidates answered this question. Stronger scripts discussed the 'resource curse' and outlined theories around resources and authoritarianism. The answers particularly considered the role of elites, institutional arrangements, rent distribution, firm ownership, clan politics, and electoral cycles. The stronger answers provided good comparative examples across the former Soviet space (rather than solely focusing on Central Asia or Eurasia). Some of the stronger scripts also argued the need to study the role of natural resources within each individual former Soviet state's economy rather than attempting to homogenise the experience across the region. The assigned grades ranged from 58-73.

Question 11. 'Scholars have focused too much on ethnicity to explain political outcomes in post-Soviet societies.' Discuss. (Low) = 1

One candidate answered this question. The assigned mark for the essay was 62.

Question 12. To what extent are elections important for the functioning of former Soviet states' political systems? (Middle) = 5

Approximately a third of all candidates answered this question. The strongest essays engaged with the existing literature on elections, voting, political parties, election fraud, and corruption in the former Soviet states. They also comparatively examined cases across the former Soviet region. Notably, no candidates who answered Question 9 also answered this question, despite the potential for overlap. The assigned grades were above average and ranged from 62-78.

Report on A12725W1 Politics in Sub-saharan Africa

Questions	Number of Answers
1	8
2	0
3	10
4	4
5	4
6	8
7	11
8	1
9	9
10	2
11	2
12	0

21 candidates sat for the examination. The examiners were pleased to access 21 typewritten e-scripts, because they are more legible than the handwritten scripts of yesteryear. The examination paper was comprised of 12 questions. All 12 questions were answered. Candidates mostly answered questions 1 (nationalist politics), 9 (civil-military relations), 3 (democratisation), and 7 (gender and politics). Questions 2 (IFIs and political economy), 4 (illiberal states), 11 (insurgencies) and 12 (politics of land reform) were the least attempted questions.

On the whole, the 2024 cohort generated very good answers to the examination questions. However, a minority of candidates did not explicitly address the questions, which cost them marks. Certain scripts in the 65% to 68% range gave somewhat unsurprising arguments and the writing did not exhibit very wide reading

5 candidates attained first class passes, but only 1 candidate got a high first and the rest achieved borderline firsts. The sole exceptional/high first candidate generated highly detailed answers characterised by well-structured compelling arguments, significant critical engagement with relevant debates, strong analysis and some signs of independent thought. The 4 borderline firsts fell short of these high standards.

The majority of marks were in the 65% to 68% range – these often did not exploit a variety of case studies and relevant literature, and they had less convincing/well supported arguments. 1 candidate failed the exam, owing to incomplete answers and unclear arguments. The second weakest script (55%), had a number of factual errors and omission of key pertinent scholarly debates. There were no cases of pronounced plagiarism/poor academic practice.

There was a low number of marks with large gaps between them, reflecting the examiners' careful attention to the assessment criteria/marking scheme, which means they were looking for the same things when marking. But the lack of many scripts with large gaps between marks also reflected the general consistency in quality of answers – as mentioned before, most marks were between 65% and 68%. In terms of the process for agreeing marks, examiners provided reasoned explanations for how marks were agreed.

For successive years now (starting in 2021), we have seen a smaller number of exceptional performances in the final exam, but the standard or quality of scripts remains very good.

Report on A12726W1 Politics of Latin America

7 PPE candidates took this exam

Questions	Number of Answers
1	6
2	4
3	2
4	3
5	1
6	1
7	1
8	0
9	0
10	0
11	3
12	0

This paper was taken by seven PPE candidates. Despite the small number of scripts this year, this was some variation in quality. There was one clear first-class honours, together with five upper seconds and one third class honours. In general, the scripts demonstrated a very good understanding of the wider theoretical literature and as is always the case with this exam, the stronger scripts matched this theoretical knowledge with solid empirical knowledge. The very best scripts could successfully critically engage with the theoretical models and could illustrate the theoretical dynamics with reference to the actual politics of the region. The weaker scripts struggled to engage with some of the more complicated theoretical ideas in the literature and these scripts also struggled to demonstrate empirical knowledge. This year, we saw a notable retreat from the previous trend for a greater spread in the choice of questions among candidates and a return to a focus on specific questions. Two questions, in particular, attracted a disproportionate amount of attention this year: Question 1 on state capacity and Question 2 on party systems. Question 11 (on economic reform) produced some of the strongest answers this year. There were no attempts at Question 8, 9, 10 or 12.

Report on A12727W1 Politics in South Asia

9 candidates took this exam. 6 PPE candidates, 3 HP candidates.

Question	Number of Answers
1	0
2	0
3	3
4	3
5	6
6	2
7	2
8	3
9	0
10	0
11	4
12	4

Twelve questions were set in this year's paper, with eight out of the twelve attempted by the nine candidates who sat the examination. The most popular question—answered by six candidates—was Question 5, which asked what continuities religious nationalism in South Asia has displayed with its colonial past, and why. Good answers to Question 5 showcased features such as: comparative regional coverage beyond a single state (although single state-focused answers showed other kinds of assets); a problematisation of the idea that *only* colonial influences should be considered when seeking to understand religious nationalism; an in-depth treatment of contemporary political practices; as also mention of alternative articulations of nationalism, beyond religion. Two further questions were each answered by four candidates: Question 11, which asked candidates to reflect on the most important historical period for the formation of caste as a social and political institution; and Question 12, which asked candidates to discuss—in relation to one or more countries in South Asia—the assertion that uneven and unequal forms of citizenship are structural features of the territorially bound nation-state. Good answers to Question 11 made an argument that spanned more than one historical period, while still making a clear choice, and/or sought to conceptually distinguish between social and political institutions, and/or argued for continuities and fluctuations in emphasis, not a periodic separation. Good answers to Question 12 offered comparative reflections across historical periods, or a comparative analysis of different inter-state borders, and/or made the important point that uneven and unequal forms of citizenship are not *only* caused by the structural features of the territorially bound nation-state. The very best answers to both questions were well-structured, commenced with a clear statement of the argument to be made in answering the question, a justification of the empirical material drawn upon, and a focused, analytical delivery of the aforementioned. The thematic choices here signalled a partial shift from the more widely-answered question themes in the 2023 exam, which were caste, post-colonial state-building, and nuclear politics in South Asia.

Questions 3 and 8, which asked candidates whether nuclear dynamics in South Asia should be considered in their global as well as in their regional context, and whether regionalism in South Asia has been successful, respectively, were each answered by three candidates. Questions 6 and 7, which enquired—comparatively—how variations in the post-colonial challenges facing South Asian states impacted their respective political trajectories in the first two decades of independence, and asked how far 'illiterate and poor peoples'… pressures for democratic governance' sustains democracy, respectively, were each answered by two candidates. Four questions, Questions 1, 2, 9 and 10, focussing on the causes and consequences of the industrial stagnation of the 1960s and 1970s in South Asia, the impact of India's federal structure on governance and democracy, the reasons for the success or failure of ecological movements, and the relation of the economic liberalisation of the 1990s to growth/development in South Asia, were not attempted. These were also, however, not questions that were popular among students during the Hilary Term revision classes.

The spread of marks awarded (for the examination as a whole) was reasonably narrow, ranging from a low 2.1 to a mid-1st, with three candidates scoring above 70%. Overall, the answers demonstrated sound conceptual understanding, wide engagement with the literature and strong empirical knowledge. Weaker answers offered less comprehensive or less clearly-structured arguments, while stronger answers developed a systematic framework for the analysis—often conceptual—and were targeted, systematic, empirically rich, critically-engaged and displayed nuance and a broad coverage of the literature.

Report on A12728W1 Politics in the Middle East

Questions	Number of Answers
1	9
2	10
3	4
4	1
5	4
6	11
7	4
8	1
9	12
10	6
11	0
12	4

Overall, this exam provided both direct options for students to demonstrate what they had revised, and more indirect opportunities for students to present bold arguments and original ways of thinking about a topic. The themes of prospects for government accountability and the bases of Islamic party support produced especially interesting, impressive, and wide-ranging results. It seems that further engagement with the themes of civil society would be welcomed by students, while the framing of the empirical study of gender in politics and of migration could perhaps be better developed.

Question 1. What are the benefits and limitations of comparing the institutional legacy of the Ottoman Empire to the institutional legacy of feudal Europe, in terms of shaping the divergent economic and political trajectories of states in these regions?

This was a popular question (9 responses), but most students answered similarly to each other. Answers ranged within the 60s, as students tended to simply repeat the arguments presented to them in the key course readings on this topic, rather than demonstrating original argumentation.

Question 2. Should we think about the state's role in Middle East and North Africa (MENA) societies as strong or weak? Answer with respect EITHER to management of the economy OR to the military and policing.

This was another popular question (10 responses). The either/or option allowed for more students to answer this question from a variety of angles, which I appreciated. It seemed evenly balanced between responses that focused on the economy and responses that focused on military and policing. The question challenged students to define what a 'strong' state is, and students answered differently, arguing for a strong or a weak state depending on their defining parameters. Answers ranged in mark from high 50s, through mid-60s, and 70s. I found this a useful exercise and believe it demonstrated a range of student ability, to think flexibly with the material they had revised, to define argument parameters, and to think both abstractly and concretely.

Question 3. How does competitive clientelism shape the politics of welfare distribution?

This question was answered 4 times, and only one of these resulted in an impressive essay. This is surprising, as this exam question draws directly on a question posed in the syllabus. It seems most students that addressed welfare and clientelism as a theme, incorporated it into answers to questions 5 and 12, rather addressing it as its own topic.

Question 4. 'Islamist parties fundamentally differ in strategy and intent from religiously affiliated political parties in Western countries.' Discuss.

This question was only answered once, but it produced interesting analysis, including a brief comparison of Egyptian and Tunisian Islamist parties to religiously affiliated EU parties. I would have liked to see more students engage with this question, but it's likely that most students' revision processes did not prepare them to take a comparative approach to this topic.

Question 5. 'Autocrats can be good for economic development, and neoliberal economic development can act as a stepping-stone to democratisation.' Discuss.

This question was answered 3 times. 2 of those times, the answers produced impressive results. I believe the question could be reworded to improve clarity, as one student seemed not to understand the implication that autocrats could promote neoliberal economic reforms. However, the students all answered soundly, with 2 students producing unique arguments backed by a breadth of empirical evidence. I think the nature of this question encourages students to think outside the box rather than simply repeat the arguments they have read. This challenge may also be why few answered it, but 2 out of 3 who did attempt it produced 1st class essays.

Question 6. Do the demands of female citizens shape government policies related to women's rights? If so, how? If not, why not?

50% of students answered this question. Many of the answers were uninspiring, in that students seemed to frequently argue that because the state policies are motivated by political incentives, they are not 'truly' motivated by what's best for women – which was not only a bit self-evident (that government policies are motivated by elite incentives) but also strayed from the question's intent and allowed students to answer in less concrete ways, with reference to fewer empirical examples. The question was not meant to invite a critique of the state's motives, but rather to get students to address the link between women's interests and political outcomes. Women's interests can affect government policies (via mediating international agencies or civil society networks or elite incentives) with or without 'benevolent intent' on the part of the state. The question, then, is to what degree these pressures on the state originate with or reflect citizen demands, regardless of avenue. Few students addressed this question in this framework. Answers to this question fell within the 62-68 mark range, with some students receiving 68 for demonstrating broad knowledge of empirical evidence to back up their argument, even if the argument as a whole was not original enough to warrant a 1st class mark.

Question 7. Agree or disagree with the following claim, with reference to THREE OR MORE cases: 'The [structures] that were crucial during the Arab Spring were not the ones that traditional civil society groups had in place…. It is in wider society, where less formal and looser ties between

politically unaffiliated youths are formed, that one finds democratising potential.' [CAVATORTA 2012]

This question was answered 4 times, with a range of marks from the 50s to the high 70s. Overall, the question produced interesting answers and creative student engagement. Some responses were a bit impassioned, but in way which elicited strong argumentation and example, rather than simply opinion. Students did seem to have strong opinions about this question, usually choosing to disagree with the provided quote and providing nuanced and well-researched reasons as to why. The question allowed students with a complex understanding of civil society networks in MENA states to shine, as other questions did not engage with literature on civil society as much. The one student who answered this question poorly seemed unprepared with background reading on the subject and unable to make a meaningful argument. I think this generally points to the fact that the course could encourage further engagement with civil society literature, both for students lacking in knowledge in this area, and for students with an apparently strong interest in engaging with this topic in depth.

Question 8. How do the political economy and welfare provisions of host countries towards citizens affect the attitudes of these citizens towards migrant communities?

This question was only answered once, and only moderately well. On the whole, this seems in keeping with tutorial patterns, in that students often choose to skip migration as an essay week. In some ways, the topic of migration seems specialised and does not appear to overlap with other course themes as clearly. So when it comes time for revision, I think students feel that the migration week is not a strategic choice for revision, as they do not perceive the readings/knowledge required to answer this question to be as adaptable as other week's topics.

Question 9. 'Support for Islamist parties stems primarily from religious beliefs and loyalties among voters.' Discuss.

In contrast to question 4, this question was quite popular. Over 50% of students answered it. Marks included one in the 80s, several in the 70s, several in the high 60s, and several in the low 60s. Overall students answered this question well. The wording of the question is relatively straightfoward, compared to other questions. Most students answered that support does not stem primarily from religious beliefs and loyalties, and many further argued that it does stem in part from religious beliefs and loyalties. While answers tended to be similar this overarching way, the answers themselves varied in terms of how robustly students drew on empirical examples, and how much their answers portrayed original thought rather than relying on repetition of the thoughts of others.

Question 10. Are the differing outcomes of mass protest and social movements across the MENA region determined by the state's repressive capacity or by civil society's capacity to organize and overcome social divisions among citizens?

This question was answered 6 times. In most instances, it resulted in essays of merit and distinction quality. The question can be answered a variety of ways, which allowed students room to make original and nuanced arguments.

Question 11. How does the political economy of a country shape government policies regarding female labour force participation? Answer with reference to TWO OR MORE cases.

No one answered this question. This is unfortunate considering that most students who answered question 6 argued that the state's policies were determined by elite incentives, an argument which would have better suited this question (if tailored to the question, that is).

Question 12. What are the prospects for greater government accountability across the MENA region?

This question was answered 4 times, with only merit- and distinction-level responses. The highest mark in the exam was given to one of these answers, as the student was able to provide a highly theoretical answer in a concise, and risky, but ultimately convincing way that did not rely on arguments presented in class. This question, being simply worded and rather open-ended, gave students scope for either hopeful or cynical analysis (sometimes a combination of both) that demanded both empirical evidence from the past and theorisation about the future.

Report on A12729W1 International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars

10 candidates: 8 in PPE; 2 in History and Politics (one candidate was missing)

Questions	Number of Answers
1	6
2	3
3	0
4	4
5	4
6	0
7	5
8	0
9	0
10	3
11	0
12	2

Question 1. Was the outbreak of the First World War the result of a 'security dilemma'?

This was a popular question among students (more than half answered it). The question asked them to connect the outbreak of this major war with a key international relations concept that realists use to explain the inherent instability of international anarchy. One excellent answer went beyond the Security Dilemma and identified a series of other systemic causes for the war, such as industrialization and colonialism. Particularly interesting was its reference to the "status anxiety" between Britain and Germany. Other good answers also emphasized systemic forces as causes of the war but did not elaborate on some important empirical points and concepts (such as "political equilibrium," which one essay defined only vaguely).

Question 2. Were Germany's grievances about the Versailles settlement legitimate?

Two students answered this question. One excellent answer provided a clear benchmark for the meaning of "legitimacy" concerning the Versailles settlement and then analysed four bases for its absence in Germany: war guilt, reparations, territorial losses, and security restrictions. The weaker response, while containing rich empirical detail and effectively referencing the literature, suffered from a dense writing style (too many compressed facts and points) and an unclear essay structure.

Question 3. Does the Treaty of Rapallo vindicate realism?

(This question received no answers.)

Question 4. Did the Soviet Union's policy of 'socialism in one country' mark a departure from the ideal of world revolution?

Several students answered this question by referring to the Soviet Union's foreign policy shift during Stalin's rule. One excellent answer correctly attributed the ideal of world revolution to the early

Bolsheviks, especially Lenin and Trotsky, who advocated for “permanent revolution,” while arguing that Stalin's foreign policy altered only the manner of its pursuit, not its nature or aims. Good answers tended to offer similar arguments but left some important historical points unexplored. One particularly interesting essay argued that while Stalin’s concept of socialism in one country abandoned the ideal of world revolution, the departure from this ideal had already begun earlier under Lenin.

Question 5. To what extent did the League of Nations embody the principle of ‘collective security’?

This question prompted students to relate the League of Nations experiment to a major concept within liberal internationalism. An excellent answer effectively described the principle of collective security, presenting a nuanced argument that while the League failed to prevent a world war, it set the stage for a more pragmatic embodiment of collective security in the form of the United Nations. Good answers provided similar arguments but did not reference the United Nations legacy (which can be helpful but is not strictly necessary). One weaker answer ranged across broad empirical topics without a focused argument centring on the League’s central organs and activities.

Question 6. Does ‘hegemonic stability theory’ successfully explain the world economy’s instability in the inter-war period?

(This question received no answers.)

Question 7. Did the League of Nations’ Mandate System serve the interests of colonized peoples?

An excellent answer to this question addressed the challenge that the Mandate System merely served the interests of Western powers, while empirically demonstrating that it helped dismantle imperial institutions on the ground in places such as Iraq and Syria. Good answers also effectively argued the opposing viewpoint. A weaker answer touched upon various cases of decolonization in the Middle East but failed to provide sufficient historical detail to substantiate its argument.

Question 8. How influential was Italian fascism in the rise of Hitler?

(This question received no answers.)

Question 9. Does the failure to embrace new military technologies explain France’s defeat in 1940?

(This question received no answers.)

Question 10. What role did ideology play in Japanese expansionism in the 1930s?

An excellent answer to this question began by establishing offensive realism as a theoretical reference point, which rejects the causal significance of ideology in explaining state behaviour. It then argued, drawing from constructivism, that ideological militarism was a driving force behind Japanese expansionism. In this case, the application of theory to empirical analysis was especially effective. Another answer that was not as good offered a similar argument but was conceptually less developed. It provided a benchmark for ideology (which is crucial for a successful answer) that was too vague to guide the historical discussion effectively.

Question 11. Does Finland's alliance with Nazi Germany invalidate 'democratic peace theory'?

(This question received no answers.)

Question 12. Was A.J.P. Taylor justified in claiming that 'Hitler did not so much aim at war as expect it to happen'?

This question received two excellent answers. One presented an interesting, nuanced argument that Hitler wanted war but did not expect it to break out, which is the reverse of Taylor's controversial statement. The analysis described the Nazi war aims in clear and compelling historical detail. Another excellent answer argued that the very nature of Nazi foreign policy made war inevitable. Both of these arguments successfully explored the ideological underpinnings of the Nazi state and their relation to its war aims.

Report on A12730W1 International Relations in the Era of the Cold War

Questions	Number of Answers
1	15
2	7
3	5
4	2
5	1
6	5
7	10
8	15
9	4
10	3
11	7
12	4

Overall students tended to choose questions on US-Soviet relations, such as the origins of the Cold War, end of the Cold War, and détente. Questions that focused on specific regions were underrepresented, particularly the questions on Western and Eastern Europe. Questions with a regional, non-great power focus also garnered weaker answers, with students showing lack of command in historical facts (particularly regarding the Middle East).

Question 1. Discuss the origins of the Cold War in relation to TWO of the following: the Marshall Plan; the Berlin Blockade (1948-9); and the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki (1945)

A very popular question with generally high achievement. Most students showed good understanding of the specific historical events mentioned (Marshall Plans, Berlin Blockade, bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki). Very good essays not only showed good detailed historical knowledge but were able to clearly connect the historical events with the theoretical arguments regarding the 'origins' of the Cold War.

Question 2. . In what sense was the Cold War 'cold'? Discuss in relation to EITHER the Cuban Missile Crisis (1962) OR the Korean War (1950-1953).

Fair number of takers, but with a noticeable degree of variance between high achieving and low achieving essays. Less successful essays tended to narrate events in detail, but failed to connect the narration of events with broader argument regarding the understanding of the Cold War as 'cold.' Many essays were comfortable regurgitating the more critical argument in literature that questions the validity of the Cold War as 'cold' but were not all successful in providing a clear reasoning for the argument.

Question 3. What impact did Khrushchev's policy of 'peaceful coexistence' have on Cold War dynamics?

Essays were generally fair and some sophisticated answers given. Generally good understanding of 'peaceful coexistence' was demonstrated by students. Strong answers were able to not only show the inconsistencies in Khrushchev's foreign policy, but also the reaction by the United States and its impact. Essays that explored the varied ways in which peaceful coexistence may have impacted the Cold War – including the unintentional or counterproductive outcomes – resulted in strong outcomes as well.

Question 4. In what sense, if any, was the Soviet Union an 'imperial power' in Eastern Europe during the Cold War?
Very few takers, and not very confident essays. Essays were a bit shaky on the conceptual understanding of 'imperialism' and uneven level of knowledge of key events during the Cold War in Eastern Europe.

Question 5. What is the significance of the Vietnam War for the Cold War?

Only one taker, resulted in a strong answer that showed good understanding of the Vietnam War as a historical event, and some fair understanding of its impact on broader areas such as regional power dynamics and US foreign policy.

Question 6. What role did ideology play in China's relations with the Soviet Union (1949-1991)?
Fair number of takers, and essays generally focused on narrating the shifts in Chinese foreign policy through changes in leadership. Less successful essays maintained an overly strong distinction between ideological and non-ideological factors, and stronger essays were able to consider the more complex and nuanced ways ideology influenced material factors and vice versa.

Question 7. How, if at all, did the Soviet intervention in Afghanistan contribute to the end of the Cold War?
Relatively popular question that resulted in a range of outcomes. Most essays were able to competently discuss the causes of the end of the Cold War and the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, but weaker essays were unable to connect the two in a coherent argument.

Question 8. 'Détente was shaped primarily by American domestic politics.' Discuss

One of the more popular questions that resulted in a number of solid essays. Stronger essays demonstrated a clearer conceptual understanding of what counts as 'domestic' politics beyond public opinion.

Question 9. What did the Non-Alignment Movement achieve during the Cold War?

Few takers, but the essays were very strong. Demonstrated clear understanding of the NAM and its influence during the Cold War.

Question 10. How did the Cold War impact European integration (1945-1991)?

Not a very popular question and generally resulted in weaker answers. Answers sometimes implicitly conflated Europe with 'Western Europe' and thus did not consider the Cold War's impact on Eastern Europe's position on the continent and vis-à-vis European integration.

Question 11. 'The Arab-Israeli conflict between 1945-1991 was primarily influenced by regional dynamics, not the global Cold War.' Discuss.

Fair number of takers but answers were very weak. Generally lacked in precision regarding historical facts and arguments were vaguely presented.
Question 12. What better explains the Cold War: bipolarity or ideological competition?

Not many takers, stronger essays considered the relationship between bipolarity and ideology, whilst weaker essays presented a very narrow reading of both concepts.

Report on A12731W1 International Relations

155 Candidates took Exam. 129 PPE candidates; 26 HP candidates

Questions	Number of Answers
1	31
2	10
3	12
4	61
5	36
6	25
7	32
8	29
9	28
10	39
11	7
12	26

This year saw 155 candidates take the International Relations exam, 129 of which were PPE students and 26 of which were HPOL students. The average mark was 65, the same as last year. The highest mark was 83, notably higher than last year's 76. The standard deviation was 8.2, which is in the standard range.

The first quartile was 62 and the median 65, which are again similar to last year. Most candidates thus demonstrated a competent grasp of the course material. The third quartile was 70, which is relatively high. There were a large number of high-quality responses this year, though markers may wish to hold scripts to a slightly higher standard in the future. Three scripts received a mark below 40, which also stands out among Politics papers. However, I do not believe that these scripts were treated with undue harshness. Indeed, a surprisingly large number of students failed to complete three answers this year, leaving examiners with little choice but to award low marks. Going forward, lecturers and tutors may wish to place greater emphasis on effective time management when preparing students for this exam.

There were no issues with the reconciliation of marks. As always, a few scripts were sent to a third examiner when a mark could not be agreed.

As is normal, a handful of questions received the bulk of responses: Q1, Q4, Q8, and Q10. Students often failed to tackle the precise question asked, ignoring nuances in wording and emphasis. For example, many answers to Q8 simply weighed the merits and demerits of different theories of the democratic peace, paying little attention to levels of analysis. Some questions were misinterpreted with alarming regularity, primarily due to a lack of familiarity with relevant literature; Q6 (which is closely related to the neoliberal institutionalist school of thought) and Q9 (which is closely related to bargaining theories of war) stood out in this regard. Pleasingly, many answers displayed an excellent command of the literature, analytical sophistication, and a willingness to engage deeply with the rubric. This was perhaps most evident with Q10. Note, finally, that Q11 received very few responses, suggesting a lack of interest in issues of nationalism and national identity among students this year.

In sum, this was a strong year for International Relations, with an unusually high number of excellent responses.

Report on A12732W1 Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau

13 candidates (9 PPE; 4 HPol)

Question	Number of answers
1	9
2	5
3	2
4	2
5	6
6	2
7	4
8	1
9	1
10	7
11	0
12	0

Overall assessment

This year saw a small cohort and fewer first-class performances than might have been expected, though those candidates who did achieve a first produced deeply impressive work. On the weaker end, there was a tendency to offer general summaries of the set texts, without attention to precise details, broader debates, or the terms of the question. To do well in this paper, candidates need to provide a clear argument that directly responds to the problems, tensions and ambiguities that the question raises. The students who are most successful develop – and persuasively deploy – their own interpretation of the named thinkers. This can only be achieved through close engagement with the nuances of the set texts. A firm grasp of context is also vital, to get a sense of why these works were written and in which debates their authors aimed to intervene.

Plato proved as popular as ever (9 takers), with Rousseau (7), Machiavelli (6) and Aristotle (5) also well represented. Alas, no takers for the thematic questions this year (on civic virtue and women's political thought), but it was encouraging to see every thinker question answered, including one answer on Hume.

Individual Questions

Question 1. How convincing is Plato's analogy between the city and the soul?

9 answers. Answers to this question were awarded the full range of marks, from 2.ii up to the highest firsts. Weaker arguments rejected the analogy out of hand on grounds such as vaguely defined totalitarianism. Stronger answers made distinctions between arguments that Plato (and his

contemporaries) might have thought convincing, and those which convince today. The very best responses could offer conceptually advanced critiques of Plato's analogy, while also taking his project seriously. Some candidates interpreted this question as purely abstract and philosophical, but those who drew out the political implications of their arguments were rewarded.

Question 2. Does Aristotle view political participation as a good in itself?

5 answers. There was a tendency in these answers to rehash descriptive summaries of Aristotle's thought, without focussing on the specifics of the question or offering much in the way of analysis. Stronger answers could focus in on various features of Aristotle's works to good effect: the meaning of 'ruling and being ruled', the value (or not) of the contemplative life, the aggregation of virtue and debate over the 'potluck meal', the ambiguous merits of rule by a single virtuous man, etc.

Question 3. 'Unbelief is not in itself inconsistent with dominion.' (THOMAS AQUINAS) Why not, and with what consequences?

2 answers. An ability to discuss the detail of the text was a crucial differentiator in this question. Precision was needed to pin down, for example, the tensions between Aquinas's discussion of the duplex regula in the Summa, his defence of infidel dominion, and the more ambiguous treatment of spiritual authority in De Regno.

Question 4. 'Their aim was to picture the awful distance between the possible and the probable.' (JUDITH SHKLAR) Do you agree with this characterisation of early utopian writing? Refer to AT LEAST ONE utopian text that you have studied for this paper.

2 answers. A small sample but included answers operating at a high degree of conceptual sophistication, drawing on multiple texts and commenting on the development of utopian writing over time.

Question 5. Which does Machiavelli value more: glory or liberty?

6 answers. Some candidates struggled to offer an answer of substance to this deceptively easy question. The best succeeded in tracing the concepts of glory and liberty in Machiavelli in detail, offering a clear and cogent account of the relationship between the two.

Question 6. What is at stake in Hobbes's 'quite peculiar concept of representation' (HANNA PITKIN)?

2 answers. A less popular question than usual (perhaps candidates were put off by the 'at stake' framing), but some good efforts to grapple with Hobbes's distinctive theory of the sovereign as representative, digging into the detail. A strong answer would recognise how this view offered a deliberate, polemical challenge to Hobbes's contemporaries, and the challenge Hobbes still poses to theorists of political representation today.

Question 7 What is the relationship, if any, between Locke's views on religious toleration and the argument of the Two Treatises of Government?

4 answers. A mix of answers. Some candidates were held back by a very limited knowledge of Locke's views on toleration and were left grasping for rather vague claims about the role of God in the

Second Treatise. Others were able to draw sophisticated parallels across Locke's texts about the limits of civil government.

Question 8. Why is Montesquieu so insistent on the need to distinguish monarchy from despotism?

1 answer. Too few for further comment.

Question 9. 'Not only as a man, but as a British subject, I pray for the flourishing commerce of Germany, Spain, Italy, and even France itself.' (DAVID HUME) On what grounds, and with what success, does Hume justify this prayer?

1 answer. Too few for further comment.

Question 10. Does Rousseau expect that man will, eventually, escape his chains?

7 answers. A popular question. Some candidates struggled to define what Rousseau meant by man's 'chains'. More impressive answers were able to draw on knowledge of the Discourse on Inequality to explain man's predicament and assess how far Rousseau believed in (or sought) the possibility of escape. Such candidates explored whether the Social Contract aimed to remove or legitimise the bonds of society, and commented on how far Rousseau thought the limits of amour propre could be transcended.

Question 11. 'The history of political thought is a history of women's exclusion.' Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO of the set authors.

No answers.

Question 12. Which was the more valuable resource for theorists of civic virtue: the political thought of ancient Greece or ancient Rome? Answer with reference to AT LEAST TWO of the set authors.

No answers.

Report on A12733W1 Political Thought: Bentham to Weber

Paper sat by 16 candidates.

Questions	Number of Answers
1	9
2	4
3	8
4	8
5	3
6	7
7	1
8	2
9	0
10	1
11	2
12	3

General Comments:

There was a reasonable spread of answers across the paper, with only one question – on science 'replacing' religion in the nineteenth century – failing to attract any takers. Taken as a whole, the knowledge of the views of the prescribed authors was good, although familiarity with the primary texts was not always well conveyed. The main discriminating factors between candidates remains their ability to use what they know in order to answer the precise question asked. The very best scripts, in addition to those exam skills, also typically demonstrate analytical sophistication and some independent critical judgment. Finally, students taking this paper are strongly encouraged to attend, and make good use of, the lectures provided for this course.

Question 1. In what ways, if any, can Saint-Simon's thought be considered 'socialist'?
This was the most popular question on the paper this year, and there was some good knowledge of Saint-Simon's views on display. Many of the better essays traced multiple reasons both for and against considering his views 'socialist', before arguing a case on the balance of that complex evidence. Accounts of what 'socialism' might be varied considerably, both in content and quality.

Question 2. Can Bentham's utilitarianism be read as an expression of 'late' Enlightenment thought?
There was plenty of good knowledge of Bentham's ideas amongst candidates, but some struggled with what the term '"late" Enlightenment thought' might mean. As ever, candidates should attempt to define technical, and quasi-technical terms in the question, even if they are not as confident about their meaning as they would like to be. An imperfect definition is nearly always better than no definition at all.

Question 3. Why is Tocqueville both pessimistic and optimistic about the prospects for democracy?
This was a very popular question. And there was some good general understanding of Tocqueville's views demonstrated (for instance, regarding differences between the two volumes of Democracy in America). However, some scripts might have benefitted from greater reflection on the causes (and not just the content) of Tocqueville's 'pessimistic' and 'optimistic' alternatives (in order to explain why he was, at different points and in different contexts, pessimistic and optimistic).

Question 4. Do Mill's views on colonial policy compromise his commitment to liberty?
This was a very popular question. Basic understanding of Mill is of a good level amongst candidates, but there was much variety in the knowledge marshalled in answering this precise question. Some candidates perhaps relied too much on Mill's remarks on 'barbarians' in On Liberty, whereas others were able to use a much wider range of material from Mill's life (his career in the East India Company) and writings (his response to the 'atrocities' committed by Governor Eyre in Jamaica, for

instance). There was some good knowledge of, and engagement with, the growing secondary literature on this topic.

Question 5. How does Hegel model the relationship between history and freedom?
Hegel is not an easy author, and it is good to see candidates attempting to get to grips with his ideas. Given the number of answers to this question generalisations are difficult. However, the dual structure of his account of freedom – its having 'objective' and 'subjective' threads – was perhaps not always sufficiently emphasised.

Question 6. Is Marx's view of history teleological?
Many answers displayed a reasonably good understanding of Marx's theory of history, but some of them struggled to relate this understanding to the precise question asked. In particular, not all answers provided a very clear or accurate account of what a 'teleological' theory of history might be. As ever, better answers attempt to define the technical and quasi-technical terms that appear in the question, and use those definitions in their overall argument.

Question 7. What is the link between Weber's scientific and political views?
Not a very popular question, and generalisations are difficult. Candidates typically perhaps had more to say about the content of Weber's scientific and political views, than about the relation between them.

Question 8. What solutions does Durkheim offer in response to the problems of the division of labour?
Not a very popular question, and generalisations are accordingly difficult. However, it is worth reminding future candidates that Durkheim's Professional Ethics and Civil Morals is also a prescribed text for the Bentham to Weber paper. It is not easy to answer this question well on the basis of The Division of Labour alone.

Question 9. 'It was science, not politics, that replaced religion in the nineteenth century.' Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.
Too few answers to comment on.

Question 10. 'The nineteenth century witnessed the discovery of the social as an object of inquiry.' Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.
Too few answers to comment on.

Question 11. Did nineteenth-century political thinkers welcome or fear the rise of the individual? Answer with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.
Not a very popular question, and generalisations are accordingly difficult. However, it is worth observing that the selection of authors in these thematic questions is important; that some comparisons are likely to be much clearer and more productive than others.

Question12. 'The degree of female emancipation is the natural measure of general emancipation.' Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.
Not a very popular question, and generalisations are accordingly difficult. However, it is worth repeating that the selection of authors in these thematic questions is important; that some comparisons are likely to be much clearer and more productive than others.

Report on A12734W1 Marx and Marxism

Paper sat by 14 candidates.

Questions	Number of Answers
1	0
2	7
3	5
4	7
5	4
6	3
7	5
8	9
9	0
10	1
11	1
12	0

Overall Comments:

There was some clustering of answers across the paper, with three questions (on Hegel, Engels, and Gramsci) attracting no takers. The level of understanding of Marxist ideas was at a good level, although some candidates seem perhaps more dependent on a small sample of secondary literature than is desirable (unless you also read the primary texts you can't fully evaluate secondary interpretations). Candidates typically varied less in their knowledge of Marx and Marxism than in their ability to deploy that knowledge in answering the precise question asked. In addition to those exam skills, the best scripts typically display analytical sophistication and some independent critical judgment. Finally, students taking this paper are strongly encouraged to attend, and make good use of, the lecture series provided for this course.

Question 1. 'Since he fiercely criticises both Hegel's metaphysics and political philosophy, it is hard to see what Marx's positive debts to Hegel might consist in.' Discuss.

Too few answers to comment on.

Question 2. Does Marx provide a clear and plausible account of what non-alienated work might look like?

A very popular question. Not all candidates appeared familiar with texts where Marx does discuss unalienated work (for example, 'Comments on James Mill' (1844)), but many made creative attempts to reconstruct his positive views by 'inverting' what he says about alienated labour (most often in the '1844 Manuscripts'). Better answers typically showed familiarity with both 'Comments on James Mill' and recent secondary literature on non-alienated work (by Jan Kandiyali, and others). They also offered some sustained independent critical reflection on the plausibility of Marx's account (for instance, questioning the feasibility of reducing alienation and maintaining productivity in communist society).

Question 3. In what areas of his thought, if any, was Marx significantly influenced by the writings of the 'utopian socialists'?

Independent knowledge of the theory and practice of utopian socialists is required for this kind of question. One cannot just rely on summaries of utopian ideas provided by Marx and Engels (who, after all, were political opponents of utopian socialists). The levels of such independent knowledge varied widely amongst candidates. Better answers typically demonstrated such knowledge, and addressed a wide range of possible areas of influence (including theories of history, criticisms of capitalism, and visions of socialism). Some candidates recognised that influence might also be negative, and that some of Marx's views may have been formed in opposition to utopianism.

4. 'Marx treats morality as synonymous with ideology; that is, as a false set of beliefs that support the interests of the capitalist class.' Discuss.

A very popular question. Candidates often had much more to say about morality than about ideology, and there was some danger of downloading prepared material on the general topic of Marx and morality. Better answers not only focused well on the precise question asked, but also saw that moral beliefs might overlap with ideology without being synonymous with it.

5. Does Marx offer any good reasons for identifying the industrial proletariat as the collective agent that can, and will, bring about communism?

There were some interesting answers to this question, showing a willingness to engage critically with Marx's views and demonstrating some sophistication in their answers (for instance, recognising that good reasons don't always successfully motivate). Not all candidates seem to have thought that the productive role of proletarians was central to Marx's identification of their ability to bring about communism (focussing more on their numbers, say, or on their being oppressed). This was also a question where relevant evidence from the primary texts was sometimes in short supply.

6. 'Happily, the relation between Marx's account of exploitation and his discredited labour theory of value is one of mutual irrelevance.' Discuss.

There is only a small sample, making generalisations difficult. However, it can be said that the accounts of Marx's labour theory of value avoided some common misunderstandings, and that the idea of 'mutual irrelevance' required, but did not always receive, some elucidation.

7. Do Marx's later reflections on Russia, in the 1870s and 1880s, involve any significant revisions to his theory of history?

Candidates' knowledge of Marx's theory of history appeared to be stronger than their knowledge of his later reflections on Russia. That said, some did demonstrate familiarity with Marx's correspondence with Zasulich, Mikhailovsky, and others, along with texts like Marx and Engels' 1882 'Preface' to the Russian edition of the Communist Manifesto. The substantive conclusions of candidates varied widely; with little consensus about whether these reflections involve any revision to Marx's theory of history, and, if they did, about their significance.

8. What might it mean for the state to lose its 'political character' in communist society? Discuss with reference, EITHER to Marx, OR to later Marxists.

The most popular question on this paper. A majority of candidates who answered it chose to do so with reference to Marx rather than later Marxists. Candidates typically recognised the relevance of what might be called republican readings of Marx, and there were some good accounts of the relevance of the Paris Commune, in particular. That said, some gave rather thin accounts of the Commune's institutional dimensions, tending to remain content with rather broad brush generalisations about participation and de-professionalisation.

9. 'He was occasionally an effective populariser of Marx's ideas, but Friedrich Engels made no independent contribution to Marxism of any significance.' Discuss.

Too few answers to comment on.

10. What are the most persuasive elements in Eduard Bernstein's critical engagement with Marx and Marxism?

Too few answers to comment on.

11. 'Marxist critics of the early years of the Bolshevik regime were overwhelmingly preoccupied with its democratic shortcomings.' Discuss with reference to ONE OR MORE of the following authors: Rosa Luxemburg, Alexandra Kollantai, Karl Kautsky, and Leon Trotsky.

Too few answers to comment on.

12. To what extent do Gramsci's Prison Notebooks embody a break with, and criticism of, his earlier pre-prison writings?

Too few answers to comment on.

Report on A12735W1 Sociological Theory

Questions	Number of Answers
1	4
2	7
3	4
4	5
5	1
6	4
7	1
8	3
9	15
10	6
11	5
12	5

Twenty candidates took this paper. The quality of most scripts was high: eleven scripts were marked in the second class, upper division and five were in the first class. Q9 (networks) was the most popular, with fifteen answers. There were seven answers for Q2 (violence) and six for Q10 (emic theories). Q4 (evolutionary psychology), Q11 (focused interactions), and Q12 (hierarchies) each attracted five answers, while Q1 (gender), Q3 (values), and Q6 (cultural evolution) each attracted four. There were three answers for Q8 (trust). Q5 (race) and Q7 (power) each had a single answer. It was pleasing to see a few candidates citing relevant recent articles which were not on the reading list.

Report on A12737W1 Political Sociology

Questions	Number of Answers
1	16
2	23
3	57
4	35
5	23
6	16
7	10
8	26
9	18
10	20
11	34
12	12

Overall, the answers showed a good understanding of substantial parts of the academic literature from the reading list, but there were often problems in identifying the most relevant research findings to answer a question or in thinking through and evaluating possible answers.

As well as showing a strong and broad knowledge and understanding of the main findings from the relevant literature on the reading list, the best candidates discussed the strengths and limitations of the evidence base they were using to support their arguments.

On a relatively minor but still important question of style, few candidates wrote effective opening paragraphs. Some were too short, giving only the main conclusion. Some were too long with too much background material. Some were unclear about what the main thesis of the essay would be or how it would be developed. As examiners we would recommend using the opening sentence to state the main conclusion and provide summaries of the key supporting points and a brief essay plan in the rest of the first paragraph.

There is no need to start with the words, “in this essay I will argue…” They are redundant if the opening sentence has a clear claim that is supported by an argument in the body of the essay.

Issues arising from particular questions are as follows:

Question 1. Does a civic political culture require a certain kind of social capital?

This question was generally well done, with better answers covering more literature more thoughtfully. Some weaker answers failed to effectively define social capital, or conflated it with civic culture, thereby rendering the claim somewhat tautological.

Question 2. How do studies of intersectionality change our understanding of the role of ethnicity in shaping political attitudes and behaviour?

This question was often badly done. A large proportion of candidates answering this question did not know what intersectionality is, defined it too broadly (to include all interaction effects with ethnicity), or misinterpreted it. Some answered primarily or solely with reference to candidates for election with little or no reference to people in society at large.

Question 3. ‘Cultural grievances might be important background conditions, but economic factors are essential for understanding when populist right parties are most successful.’ Discuss.

This was a popular question and most had a lot to say about economic and cultural factors broadly. Very few seriously addressed the question of “when” populist right parties do well and when they do badly. The vast majority wrote vaguely about factors correlated with voting for populist right parties

without considering which of them vary over time in a way that might help account for variation in macro performance at elections over time within countries. Very few said anything about the pattern of party performance the question was asking candidates to explain, that is how populist right party support has varied over time and when each populist right party has been successful (if at all). Moreover, few picked up on the suggestion in the quotation that cultural grievances might be relatively long-standing and slow to change and so explain relatively little of short-term fluctuations in party performance. Better answers distinguished more carefully between the roles of economic attitudes of individuals and the effects of temporal variation in macro-economic circumstances.

Although lengthy discussion of what defines "populist right parties" is not needed if a fairly standard conception is used, candidates should show some indication of how they think the category can be identified. A few candidates slipped into referring to "populism" when they meant populist right parties or were ambiguous as to what they meant.

Question 4. What do cross-national differences reveal about the role of gender in politics?

Better answers to this question focused on cross-national differences, even if they ultimately also argued that the patterns of change over time that are common to many Western democracies are actually more informative than cross-national differences. Weaker answers simply sought to highlight cross-national differences without analysing what these differences reveal about the role of gender.

Question 5. Is nationalism primarily reactive?

Many struggled to mention any ways in which nationalism (including national identities) might develop within a society (either organically or proactively) without being primarily a reaction to some external groups, events, or developments. Better answers showed more awareness of more different processes affecting the development of national identities and nationalist movements. Even if they argued that all the processes were ultimately reactive, better answers at least considered alternative interpretations. For instance, national identity formation in Europe might be characterised as the product of, rather than a reaction to, modernisation.

Question 6. What role does faith play in the politicisation of religion?

There were relatively few answers to this question, and no systematic issues arising.

Question 7. Who protests and why?

There were relatively few answers to this question, and no systematic issues arising.

Question 8. Why do levels of electoral turnout change over time?

Better answers focused more on change over time. While many answers framed the argument around the paradox of voting, some used this more effectively to engage with the question about changes over time, whereas weaker responses were overly focused on static or cross-sectional factors affecting turnout.

Question 9. How does elite power vary between countries?

Better answers focused more on variation between countries. Essays that provided clear definitions of elites and elite power were more effective.

Question 10. What do people want from welfare states?

Better answers considered both different aspects of welfare states that people have views about and variation between different people in what they want.

Question 11. 'Media effects depend more on consumer behaviour than on media content.' Discuss.

Better answers were more thoughtful on the ways in which consumers affect media markets and have influence in social media algorithms, even if they ultimately argued that content was more important. Some answers failed to effectively define consumer behaviour, or to clarify what aspects of consumer behaviour matter, and why.

Question 12. Are problems within states as organisations the primary cause of civil wars and revolutions?

There were no systematic issues arising with this question.

Report on A12740W1 Social Policy

There were 34 candidates (29 PPE, 5 MHP) assessed through the politics exam board, as well as an additional 4 Human Sciences candidates.

Questions	Number of Answers
1	5
2	10
3	11
4	9
5	8
6	5
7	16
8	2
9	17
10	7
11	4
12	5

As in past years, the scripts this year were of high quality. Candidates showed a strong theoretical and empirical knowledge of British and comparative social policy. Stronger answers generally displayed more depth in both areas. The strongest scripts were exceptionally detailed in terms of policy and academic literature and used this detail to effectively answer the question. These scripts tended to define the core terms in the prompt and then use their definitions to structure the argument, developing an analytic framework to address the prompt clearly. Better scripts demonstrated not just solid knowledge of the history and structure of policy but also the academic literature about these developments Some scripts cited very little academic material, which generally cost them marks. A small number of scripts took a more polemical approach, asserting relatively strong but weakly evidenced arguments, an approach that generally was not successful. Many scripts showed good knowledge of the academic/policy material, but would have benefitted from more analytic clarity in linking this material to the question and the debates that the question points to.

Question 1. 'The policies of the British welfare state have changed dramatically over the last 70years, but the core purposes of social policy remain very much:

Most scripts displayed basic knowledge of the overtime development of key welfare programs in Britain. Better answers set out a conceptual framework for defining the 'core purposes' of the British welfare state and then analysed these historical developments in line with this framework. Weaker answers tended to present a historical narrative but without a strong analytic framing.

Question 2. What are three main contributions of Esping Andersen's welfare regimes typology to the study of welfare states?

Most answers showed strong knowledge of Esping-Andersen's welfare regime typology, but several struggled to pull out a larger set of claims about its contribution (or lack thereof). Better answers reflected on the purpose and contribution of the regime typology for structuring comparative welfare research, as well as on its limits.

3. 'Who pays for welfare – public or private – matters far more than who provides it.' Discuss.

This question was relatively popular, and answers were generally of high quality. Better answers developed some type of conceptual framework for defining what 'matters far more' might mean, and then evaluated the evidence considering this framework. Answers took the question in several different directions, some looking at questions of equity, others at efficiency, and yet others at the nature of democratic control, and then really examined the empirical literature on different welfare mixes. Weaker answers tended to summarise a narrow range of literature on private financing or

provision, but without a clear analysis of the question or framework for evaluating the importance of different organisational forms.

4. Is it possible to combine a big welfare state with high levels of immigration?

Another popular question. Answers were generally strong, and engaged with the literature. Better answers looked at multiple mechanisms linking welfare states to immigration – e.g. electoral support, labor market structure, the logic of benefits – and really analysed the extent to which existing evidence shows a tradeoff. Some answers pushed the argument further, looking to define the scope conditions for the combining welfare and immigration. Several weaker answers either cited little academic material (taking a more speculative approach) or had vague and unclear arguments that did not acknowledge the broader debate they were speaking to.

5. What are the strengths and weakness of an NHS-style health care system relative to other organizational forms (e.g. social insurance, private health insurance)?

This question was generally well done, but many answers narrowed in on a comparison between the NHS and private health insurance (often with specific reference to the US) without discussing social insurance. The best answers set up a clear set of criteria for analysing the 'strengths and weaknesses' of different health care systems, and then systematically worked through the literature on private, social insurance, and NHS systems. Many of these answers challenged these core institutional distinctions, pointing to variation within NHS-style systems. Several excellent answers showed a depth of reading and research on health care that allowed for highly detailed answers. Weaker answers tended to deal with the literature in a superficial or limited way, or lacked an analytic framework with which to analyse differences.

6. What factors account for the main developments in UK labour market policy over time?

Very few answered this question. As with other questions, successfully answering this question required both a clear framework for analysing labour market policy and a strong set of empirical details about the trajectories of policy.

7. 'The level of poverty in Britain is a political choice.' Discuss.

A popular question. Most answers agreed with the prompt, arguing that cross-national and over-time variation in the rates of poverty demonstrate that policies (in particular welfare policies) are critical to shaping the level of poverty. Better answers defined poverty (and competing conceptions of poverty) in clear ways, and then looked to unpack the mechanisms that produce poverty, tracing the effects of policy via these mechanisms. Weaker answers either suffered from a lack of policy detail – pointing to broad trends in poverty without an analysis of policy or politics – or provided detail but without an analytic framework that linked the detail to the question.

8. How are old age pension schemes in affluent countries changing to cope with the financial pressure of population aging?

There were very answers to this question.

9. To what extent do educational policies reduce inequalities in attainment across social groups?

One of the most popular questions. Answers were generally high quality. Most candidates looked to describe inequalities in attainment, and then queried the extent to which policies matter. Better answers examined the evidence connecting both social background to attainment and way different types of policies could strengthen or weaken these connections, looking at both the aggregate evidence on policy effects and the more disaggregated evidence on particular policies vis-à-vis particular inequality producing mechanisms. Some answers bordered on being polemical, rather than academic, citing less material or analysing outcomes clearly.

10. How do varying family policies rest on different understandings of the family?

There were some very strong answers to this question, and several that missed the mark in terms of clarity in answering the question. The better answers really spent time building on the key point of the prompt – how policies build on and construct different understandings of the family – and then either systematically analysed different components of British family policy or examined the question from a comparative perspective. Weaker answers gestured at different understandings of the family (e.g., pointing to variation in 'breadwinner' policies) but were less systematic in their approach to the theoretical question or had little empirical breadth to demonstrate variation.

11. 'In the last two decades, UK policy has moved towards recognising, and building on, the social model of disability.' Discuss.

Answers to this question were generally very good, and some were exceptional in their level of detail and knowledge of the academic and empirical material. Strong answers set out, in conceptual terms, the social model of disability, and then developed an analytic yardstick through which to assess whether the UK had actually moved towards it. In some cases, the answers displayed a deep and detailed knowledge of not just the policies, but also the processes that produced them, and used this knowledge to really engage with the core question.

12. Do we know enough about 'what works' to justify the adoption of an evidence based approach to policy design?

There were only a handful of answers to this question, but they were generally good. Most reflected on both the prompt and the literature on social policy analysis in a clear and careful way.

Report on A12741W1 Comparative Demographic Systems

Questions	Number of Answers
1	1
2	0
3	0
4	0
5	0
6	0
7	0
8	1
9	0
10	1
11	0
12	0

Too few candidates took this exam to comment.

Report on A12743W1 Politics in China

11 PPE candidates; 0 in History and Politics

Questions	Number of Answers
1	1
2	3
3	2
4	8
5	4
6	1
7	2
8	1
9	3
10	1
11	4
12	3

General Comments:

This year answers were less spread out than in previous years, due in part to the relatively small number of candidates who sat the exam. The better prepared candidates were able to showcase both their knowledge of the assigned readings as well as their analytical capacity, which earned them first-class marks. Less well-prepared candidates reverted to summaries of the lecture notes.

A few students were able to rehearse debates amongst scholars represented on the assigned reading list and to then append views of their own. The most successful candidates had read widely and thought carefully about the material, and the underlying dynamics that shape the politics of China, particularly in light of the Xi era.

Question One How did the relationship between the Party and the state change over the course of the Mao era, and why? [2 answers]

Solid answers demonstrated clear knowledge of the historic events and offered analysis of the prevailing explanations in the assigned scholarly literature.

Question Two: Have the lessons that the Party-state drew from the 1989 Tiananmen protests made the regime more resilient over the past 35 years?? [3 answers]

The stronger answers demonstrated clear understanding of the various understandings of the Tiananmen Square protests, and the recent literature on the Party-state's attempts to learn from it. The best answers of course referred to the general precepts laid out in the so-called "princeling manifesto" (Realistic Responses and Strategic Options for China after the Soviet Upheaval).

Question Three: In 1978, Deng Xiaoping maintained that only an efficient market economy integrated with the capitalist West could maintain the Chinese Communist in power after Mao's death. Was he right?.[1 Answer]

Question Four: Why did the regime's single-minded focus on growth during the post-Tiananmen era, which caused rising income equality and an inadequate supply of social services, not destabilize Chinese society? [8 answers]

A popular question this year. Stronger answers were able to identify and describe the broad range of policies and practices used to defuse and deflect protest, and to offer a sophisticated review and assessment of the key readings, including those related to the so-called "social volcano" debate.

Weaker answers showed little familiarity with the assigned readings on the topic.

Question Five: "Empowering legal institutions and positioning the Party leadership as a champion of legality against traditional bureaucratic corruption has been a major source of both personal status and populist political legitimacy." Discuss? [4 answers]

Admittedly speculative in some ways, the most successful answers were able to clearly explain what the 'rule of law' vs. 'rule by law' debate is and why the Chinese leadership are so committed to finding a way around it. The best answers also referred to the assigned readings on legitimacy and how it has tended to operate during the reform era. Weaker answers had an unclear grasp of the concepts involved and provided little informed discussion of recent policy.

Question Six: 6. Does China's reluctance to end its 'zero-COVID' policies demonstrate that the paradigm of 'adaptive authoritarianism' is now obsolete?? [1 answer]

Question Seven: 7. What does the regime's response to the "A4" (or "blank paper") protests of November 2022 tell us about how the Party-state's ability to respond popular contention has changed since 1989? [2 answers]

Question Eight 8: Which is more destabilizing in China today: demographic imbalances or ethnic inequalities?. [1 answer]

Question Nine: Why has the representation of women in China's two legislative bodies declined in recent years, despite Xi's 2015 promise to "take equality between men and women as fundamental, and break the backward concepts and stereotypes that hinder the development of women"? [3 answers]

Although not attracting a large number of answers, the submissions were strong as a group. The better answers demonstrated clear understanding of how representation works in the Chinese legislature, as well as the recent speeches of Party-state leaders on gender inequality.

Question Ten: Is "Xiconomics" chiefly a response to internal (domestic) or external (international) pressures? [1 answer]

Question Eleven: To what extent is Xi's China challenging the international order? [4 answers]

Some good answers to this question demonstrated clear knowledge of the historic events and offered analysis of the prevailing explanations in the assigned scholarly literature on the international relations of China.

Question Twelve: How has the mainland's relationship with Hong Kong and Taiwan evolved since 1978? [3 answers]

A good deal of variation in the answers to the question, in part due to the need to balance a historical understanding of mainland policy toward both Hong Kong and Taiwan. The strongest essays managed to demonstrate familiarity with recent historic events, as well as to offer an analysis of shifting Chinese priorities over time.

Report on A12744W1 Politics of the European Union

Seven (five PPE students and two MHP) students sat this paper.

Questions	Number of Answers
1	1
2	2
3	0
4	0
5	4
6	6
7	1
8	1
9	0
10	2
11	1
12	3

Students had to answer 3 out of 12 essay questions, and the distribution of chosen questions ensured that students had to draw on diverse set of topics that had been covered throughout the course. The topics included Common Foreign and Security Policy, the EU in crisis, theories of European integration, European Union institutions and institutional reforms. The strong engagement with a diverse set of topics shows that students have developed a broad range of interests. In addition to discussing recent political challenges such as EU foreign and security policy and the impact of the recent crisis, students have also reflected on theoretical debates and evaluated the explanatory power of different theoretical approaches.

One student did very well and was awarded the highest mark 75, two exams were above 60 (upper second) two exams were above 50 (lower second), one exam was awarded third (43) and one pass in finals/honour modes (37) . The mean was 57.28 This result is lower compared to previous years. The exam awarded a mark of 37 (pass) showed some grasp of the material. Exams awarded lower second class showed appropriate understanding of some of the key concepts, but were limited in scope or contained notable deficiencies in analysis. Exams above 60 were able to present their argument in a coherent and correct fashion but were more limited in scope and lacked wider political considerations and critical reflection. Exams above 65 had to showcase the ability of independent analysis, even with missing aspects or few shortcomings. The two exams marked 73 needed to go beyond what had been covered in the lectures, go beyond textbook chapters and had to display a critical engagement with the wider academic scholarship. They showcased excellent factual knowledge about a wider variety of different aspects, a sound line of analytical argumentation, with convincing critical reflection.

Report on A15594W1 Special Subject in Politics: International Security and Conflict

47 candidates: 39 in PPE; 8 in History and Politics

Questions	Number of Answers
1	10
2	17
3	21
4	13
5	17
6	20
7	3
8	2
9	18
10	1
11	8
12	7

PPE and HP candidates broadly chose similar questions to answer.

Question 1. Should the concept of national security be revisited?

This conceptually oriented question allowed students to connect ongoing empirical trends in international security (such as China's rise, climate change, cyberattacks, and terrorism) with mainstream IR theories, particularly neorealism, with its statist and military focused conception of security, and their challengers. The best answers demonstrated a strong understanding of relevant IR debates about the contested notion of "security" against the backdrop of major phenomena such as the decline of U.S. global hegemony, Russia's war in Ukraine, and the Covid-19 pandemic. Good answers displayed a competent conceptual understanding of security but engaged less with relevant theories and debates. Poor answers lacked analytical depth and empirical detail: for example, by vaguely connecting national security and individual security to argue that "human security" has become more important. Some responses were notably interesting and creative because they successfully related factors across IR's three levels of analysis.

Question 2. Why do interstate wars occur, given their high costs?

This question was theory heavy: it prompted students to analyse the intricate interplay of political and social forces that lead to interstate war despite its significant (sometimes tragic) costs. Key concepts and perspectives include the realist Security Dilemma within international anarchy, bargaining failures, and conflicts fuelled by identity. The best responses effectively integrated generalizing theories (e.g. Fearon's rationalist theory of war) with detailed empirical illustration. Good answers also examined general theories, including Fearon's, but with less empirical depth or theoretical nuance. Weak answers tended to just review some of the main arguments of the field or

oversimplify: they showed a limited understanding of the topic's complexity and contentious nature. Some intriguing responses questioned whether a phenomenon as multifaceted as interstate war, arising from both material and social forces, can truly be subjected to generalizing causal analysis.

Question 3. Do individuals join civil wars primarily for material gains?

This question was more focused: it provided students with the opportunity to apply or challenge general theories and concepts of international security within a narrow empirical setting. Excellent answers effectively navigated theoretical debates (e.g. between Kalyvas's rationalist model and Abrahms's critique of it) while connecting individual motives with broader group dynamics. Good answers engaged competently with relevant theories, even if they lacked some empirical detail. Weak answers tended to cover multiple cases superficially (e.g. the Bosnian War and Rwandan Genocide) without meaningfully analysing any single one or just repeated the arguments of an established theory. This question was particularly popular among students (both PPE and HP).

Question 4. 'Politically counterproductive, but tactically necessary.' Discuss this view of terrorism and/or counterinsurgency.

While not overly theoretical, this empirically grounded question allowed students to analyse and critique theories of terrorism and insurgency. Strong answers argued that the statement in the question is somewhat simplistic. They provided clear definitions of terrorism and explored methods to combat it in various contexts (e.g. Afghanistan and Nigeria), linking these methods back to the root causes (often social) of terrorism and insurgency. Good answers covered similar ground but with less extensive reference to literature and specific cases. Weak essays lacked historical context, resulting in shallow and ambiguous analysis, or only responded to one of the two key concepts in the prompt (the two being counterproductive and necessary). The main focus across essays was on terrorism, rather than insurgency

Question 5. Are mass atrocities solely fuelled by hatred?

This monocausally phrased question pushed students to consider the complex drivers of genocide and mass atrocities. The strongest answers tapped into theoretical debates about the strategic utility and motivations of mass killing and then analysed the insights of these debates through the prism of a specific case or two. Empirically, there was much focus on the Rwandan genocide, although some essays examined more historical cases such as the Holocaust. Weak answers tended to be thin on empirical detail. For example, essays that superficially mentioned multiple genocides such as in China, Cambodia, Rwanda, and Bosnia would probably have done better had they focused on just one or two cases.

Question 6. Under what circumstances do nuclear weapons contribute to the establishment of peace?

This question taps into longstanding debates about nuclear stability and peril in international relations. It was a very popular question among students (perhaps reflecting its long history and renewed salience in light of great power tensions today). The strongest answers effectively reviewed the literature and debates, with special emphasis on Waltz's "nuclear peace" argument. Although much of the empirical focus was on superpower relations during the Cold War, some interesting answers referred to ongoing wars in Ukraine and Gaza. Weaker answers tended to gloss over

important critiques of Waltz's theory (such as the risk of catastrophe arising from misperception or irrational state behaviour) or just repeated Waltz's argument as their own analysis.

Question 7. Why, and with what consequences, are regional initiatives to enhance security becoming more common?

This question received only three answers: a strong one, a good one, and a weak one. The strong answer analysed the evolution of regional security organizations such as NATO from the Cold War to the present, with a broad regional focus that also covered ASEAN and the African Union. The good answer also covered various regions, but provided less empirical depth (particularly on NATO). The weak answer made almost no references to the literature and offered only empirical snippets.

Question 8. Are forcibly displaced people more likely to be targets or agents of violence?

This question attracted only two answers, both of them good. One was empirically rich, featuring strong discussions of displacement in Somalia, Ethiopia, and Kosovo. The other focused more on the drivers of displacement, with a thinner analysis of its historical manifestations and implications for violence.

Question 9. How might the internal organization of a rebel group account for the differences in levels of sexual violence during civil conflicts?

This popular question received diverse forms of analysis. The best ones showed a strong grasp of the scholarly literature (Cohen, Wood, Weinstein, etc.), which they applied to analyse diverse cases of sexual violence. Good answers also fared well in the literature review, and discussed pertinent cases, but featured a less clear organization, gaps in analysis, or repetition of the main arguments of the field. Weak answers delved into historical cases but sidestepped important theoretical debates (e.g. by focusing mainly on Cohen).

Question 10. 'Success comes down to a matter of legitimacy.' Discuss this view in relation to nonviolent resistance and/or international counter-piracy measures.

This question received only one, very good answer focusing on nonviolent resistance (rather than counter-piracy). Referring to relevant literature (e.g. Schock, Stephan and Chenoweth), it argued that nonviolent means of resistance aid its legitimacy. The analysis made varied reference to civil uprising during the Arab Spring, with a special focus on Libya under Gaddafi.

Question 11. Have new technologies reshaped security dynamics within international politics?

This was a popular question. The strongest answers demonstrated a good grasp of the technical underpinnings of cyberspace while exploring the international security implications of drones and emerging AI systems. One interesting argument discussed biased algorithmic data inputs, which could lead to prejudiced weapons targeting. A common observation among several essays was the effect of cyberspace on power diffusion away from states towards other actors, complicating the governance of new technology. Weak answers tended to focus on narrow aspects of the topic, such as the "chokepoint" effects of computerized global finance, while missing the larger strategic dimensions, such as conflict deterrence dynamics.

Question 12. In what ways can Blue Helmets mitigate conflicts?

Because of its historical depth, this question attracted diverse analysis. Strong answers effectively related the concept of “peace” (with its various possible meanings) to peacekeeping efforts on the ground, while engaging with the copious scholarly literature. Weak essays skirted (or just summarized) the literature and glossed over historical details (e.g. by focusing too narrowly and superficially on Afghanistan). One especially interesting essay argued that peacekeeping methods of persuasion, rather than coercion, were more effective.

Report on A15601W1 Advanced Papers in Theories of Justice

37 Candidates took this exam. 34 PPE candidates, 3 HP Candidates.

Question	Number of Answers
1	3
2	17
3	20
4	11
5	17
6	13
7	4
8	10
9	8
10	4
11	0
12	1

The quality of answers this year was very good. 3 candidates received marks below 59, 24 in the 60-69 range, 9 in the 70-79 range, and one in the 80+ range. Nearly all scripts showed pleasing familiarity with the source material for the paper, and there was less reliance on lecture materials than has been noted in previous years. The highest marks went to candidates who were able to use the literature to develop their own focused responses to the questions. The most popular questions were on environmental justice, migration, and intergenerational justice. A tricky historic injustice question saw fewer answers than is normal. It is striking that the UBI question was also reasonably popular, though there were fewer answers on health and trade.

Question 1. Does the pursuit of global justice require the abolition of trade protectionism? (3 responses)
Too few answers for comment.

Question 2. Do states have any rights to limit the numbers of refugees crossing their borders? (18 responses)
The key difference between essays here was the willingness of candidates to focus on refugees specifically, rather than simply relying on more general discussions of the right to exclude migrants.

Question 3. Is it reasonable to hold present day states responsible for the costs of historic carbon emissions? (20 responses)
The most popular question, and the one where essays seemed to be most in thrall to the lecture materials. Nonetheless some good knowledge of relevant literature, and some interesting reflections on how to interpret “reasonable” in the question.

Question 4. Does the literature on historic injustice pay sufficient attention to the agency of the subjects of colonialism? (12 responses)
A challenging question, which perhaps explains the relatively low number of responses in relation to what is traditionally a popular topic. Some essays would have benefited from saying more about the

concept of "agency" in play, but there was some good engagement with literature on, for example, structural injustice, and apologies and commemoration.

Question 5. 'We can neither wrong nor harm future generations by performing actions that cause them to come into existence.' Discuss. (18 responses)
A popular question. Better answers both avoided boilerplate material on the Non-Identity Problem and were careful to differentiate between harms and wrongs.

Question 6. 'A society is just in relation to disability insofar as people with disabilities and without disabilities have the same level of welfare.' Discuss. (13 responses)

This was generally well answered – the question seemed to dissuade candidates from making the distinction between the medical and social models the sole focus of their essays, and there was some interesting engagement on empirical data on the experiences of disabled people and reflection on neurodiversity.

Question 7. Does it make sense to think of individuals as having a right to health? (4 responses)
A small number of responses, but some variation in the degree of familiarity candidates displayed in relation to relevant scholarly literature.

Question 8. 'The introduction of Universal Basic Income would entail the exploitation of the industrious by the lazy.' Discuss. (10 responses)

This was generally answered well, with candidates demonstrating impressive familiarity with both empirical and theoretical material.

Question 9. Should the costs of raising children fall exclusively on parents? (8 responses)

It was clear that some candidates were familiar with the syllabus readings that directly address this question and others were not: unsurprisingly, those who had encountered the debate previously tended to do better.

Question 10. 'The pursuit of justice requires revolution, not reform.' Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO topics studied in this paper. (4 responses)
Some interesting answers here, though the revolutionary action suggested did not always seem *that* revolutionary!

Question 11. 'Taking intersectionality seriously means avoiding thinking about different policy areas in isolation from each other.' Discuss. (0 responses)

0 responses.

Question 12. Does contemporary theorising about justice focus too much on the state? (1 response)

Too few answers for comment.

Report on A17325W1 Comparative Political Economy

Question	Number of Answers
1	18
2	10
3	1
4	3
5	16
6	6
7	1
8	5
9	7
10	8
11	10
12	2

Question 1. 'The trade-off between equality and efficiency is false.' Discuss. [17 answers]

Most popular question. In most cases, competent answers with adequate use of literature and evidence. But often superficial summaries, rather than interesting analyses.

Question 2. Are advanced industrial states really constrained by globalization or is this a convenient excuse for certain types of policy? [10 answers]

A popular question. Like the previous one, it mostly produced competent answers that summarized some of the literature and evidence, but did not provide interesting analyses.

Question 3. 'The most important actor in advanced industrial economies is the central bank.' Discuss with reference to the implications for the effectiveness of democracy. [1 answer]

Only one answer to this question. Not a popular topic, but a good answer when chosen.

Question 4. Are there still important differences in the financial structure of advanced industrial economies? [3 answers]

Unpopular question with highly variable answers when chosen.

Question 5. Is the 'Varieties of Capitalism' approach too dependent on evidence from Germany and the United States to be persuasive? [16 answers]

Very popular question with highly variable answers. Many answers adequately summarised the Varieties of Capitalism approach. The best answers addressed directly the Germany/US dependence mentioned in the question.

Question 6. Do electoral systems affect government spending? [7 answers]

Some competent answers that summarized the obvious literature. The best answers addressed the connection to government spending more analytically.

Question 7. Are theories of economic institutions and public policies better at describing institutional changes than explaining them? [1 answer]

Only one answer to this question. Not a popular topic, and not a great answer. Competent at summarizing some institutional literature, but less so at applying it to the concrete question about change.

Question 8. Are the post-war economic trends of 'post-industrialism' and 'dualization of labour markets' distinct in their political implications? [5 answers]

Not a very popular question, but the answers to it were better than average. Most answers provided a good analysis of both post-industrialism and dualization (whatever the concrete argument).

Question 9. How does the rise of the 'knowledge economy' affect democratic capitalism? [7 answers]

Very variable answers despite the limited number of people choosing this question. Some answers were poor (and either misunderstood some of the literature or focused too much on one contribution), some were competent in terms of summarizing the literature (but uninspiring), and very few managed to produce an interesting analysis in response to the question.

Question 10. 'The strength of social democratic parties is the most important factor to explain differences in the expansion of the welfare state between countries.' Discuss. [8 answers]

Like the previous question, very variable answers despite the limited number of people choosing this question. In general, there were more weak answers (misunderstanding some of the literature or producing superficial summaries) than for the rest of the questions in the exam.

Question 11. Is income inequality a significant determinant of redistribution preferences? [11 answers]

Generally good answers to this question (with some variability). There were few excellent answers, and most of the good ones mostly summarized the literature in a competent but uninspiring way.

Question 12. Does the demand for redistribution translate into supply of redistribution in industrialized democracies? [3 answers]

Not a very popular question, but the answers to it were better than average.

Report on A17606W1 Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory

Question	Number of Answers
1	4
2	13
3	2
4	5
5	1
6	9
7	0
8	8
9	3
10	2
11	2
12	8

Exam Report to follow